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ALT 111: INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY GENRES

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INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY GENRES

Introduction

In this unit we present you with a course that introduces the major forms of literature: poetry, prose fiction, oral literature, biography, autobiography and the essay. This course gives you a general overview of the nature of literature and its modes of presentation. Having understood the nature of various genres of literature, this course shows you how to identify, describe and discuss features of literary matter.

Objectives

At the end of this unit you should be able to:

- (a) Recognize the various forms (genres) of literature.
- (b) Recognize and be able to discuss the various techniques used in literary communication.
- (c) Have a basic knowledge of different approaches and analytical methods used in the appreciation of literature.
- (d) Recognize the functions of the various literary genres in society.

The following books on the primary texts list are essential for your understanding of the various literary forms. The secondary reading list at the end of this course should be able to provide a broader background.

PRIMARY TEXTS

- 1) Cook, D & D. Rubadiri: *Poems from East Africa*. Nairobi: E.A.E.P.

OR

2) Amateshe, A.D. (1988): *Anthology of East African Poetry*. Harlow: Longman.

3) Imbuga, F. (1988): *Aminata*. Nairobi: E.A.E.P.

OR

4) Imbuga, F. (1976): *Betrayal in the City*. Nairobi: E.A.E.P.

OR

5) Ruganda, J. (1972): *The Burdens*. O.U.P

6) Achebe, C. (1958): *Things Fall Apart*. Nairobi. Heinemann.

OR

7) Wa Thiong'o, N. (1966): *A Grain of Wheat*. Nairobi: Heinemann.

8) Miruka, O. (1994): *Encounter With Oral Literature*. Nairobi: E.A.E.P.

9) Bukenya, et. Al. (1994): *Understanding Oral Literature*. Nairobi: Nairobi University Press.

LESSON ONE

WHAT IS LITERATURE?

1.0 Introduction

This is our first lecture in this course. In it we will look at the nature of literature. We shall then attempt to evaluate this nature in relation to the function of literature.

1.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define the term 'Literature' in more specific terms.
2. Describe the nature of literature and its modes of presentation.
3. Get a general overview of the function of Literature.

1.2 Nature of Literature

In a general sense, the term 'literature' may allude to almost any form of recorded discourse, from political parties' constitutions, billboard advertisements and recipes to scholarly work. However, *literature* or *poetry* (the term preferred by classical critics to designate imaginative literature), in the special sense we use it here is confined to creative art whose medium is the word. What this means is that language is the main factor that distinguishes literature from other forms of art. Language is the material used to mould literary art. The language that creative literature uses is different from the ordinary, the usual, in the sense that creative literature re-organizes the resources of everyday language. This re-organization may even entail flagrant violation of linguistic norms. Such violation is usually employed deliberately by an author in order to: (i)

foreground (make stand out) the linguistic item in question and therefore compel the reader into awareness and attention, (ii) in order to make their meaning forceful and clear, (iii) in order to arouse certain emotions in the reader and (iv) to inculcate certain attitudes in the reader. For example, in order to make his stand clear as regards his abhorrence of corruption, in a poem entitled "I refuse to take your brotherly hand", Henry Barlow engages in semantic violation (violation with regard to meaning): "filthy fingernails rob me my pride". It is obvious that an abstract idea like pride cannot be robbed. However, this kind of violation is more forceful and crisp than saying: 'engaging in corruption will make me feel worthless'.

The personification that Bukenya employs in his poem "I met a thief" such as "whispering coconut towers", "growling, foaming waves", "Intimate cashew boughs", "peeping weeds", go

a long way in making the point that nature was not only in harmony with the persona's new found love but even jealous.

Such examples demonstrate that literary language is highly connotative. What this means is that literary language points to a reality beyond itself as opposed to literal language which is purely denotative – alludes to an objective referent. That literature uses language as its medium notwithstanding, literature imposes some kind of framework, order in the language to distinguish it from ordinary language. This re-organization is also done extra- linguistically, all these with the aim of *persuading* the reader or listener. Indeed, the ultimate aim of a literary writer is to express a certain viewpoint and persuade the audience or reader into recognizing certain truths and taking a stand. In this regard, imaginative literature begins with an emotion on the part of the writer. You cannot just wake up one day and begin to write. You must feel something about an aspect of life to be able to write about it. Literature is therefore emotional in the sense that it imaginatively presents the writer's emotions with a view to influencing the audience into sharing in the emotion. Sometimes, the writer's emotion is a universal one. However, the writer creatively concretizes or discredits this emotion with a view to instigating action in order to gratify or nullify the emotion. In its expressive nature, literature conveys the

attitude of the speaker or writer towards the illusion of reality presented in his art. By so doing, a literary artist aims at influencing the position his audience will take.

It is indisputable that you can only persuade a person on an issue that conveys some sense to the respondent. This means that literature has to make sense to convince. One can only make sense by addressing a subject of common knowledge. What this means is that despite its *extra-ordinary* language, literature cannot avoid being premised on the ordinary happenings. Literature is therefore of essence *mimetic* in nature where mimetic means *reflective* of the societal happenings. Plato's conception of imitation (mimesis) recorded in his book *The Republic* could rightly be acknowledged as the earliest view of literature as a reflection of society.

In its reflective nature, literature has value as a criticism of life. A writer does not merely imitate reality for the sake of it. Rather, the writer reflects aspects of reality with a view to demonstrate the good and the bad. Implicit in this reflection is a castigation of the evil and appreciation of the good. In that regard, literature makes a declaration about the qualities that life does not have but should have. As society changes, so does its literature change. Literature is part of a social growth and not simply its reflection. Louis de Bonald, a French philosopher and writer, was one of the first writers to argue that through a careful reading of a nation's literature, one could be able to tell what these people had been.

Activity

What is the nature of literature?

1.3 Function of Literature

The natures of literary phenomena dictate their function in society. According to a classical critic, Horace, literature is *util et dulce*. This means that literature is *useful* (*util*) and *sweet* (*dulce*) at the same time. Literature is useful because it only in the emotional release (catharsis) it provides to those who devour it. Literature is sweet in giving pleasure by the very skill the author employs to convince or create an illusion of reality. Utility and entertainment will not only co-exist but also coalesce in a good literary work.

In terms of specific functions, firstly, literature is an important avenue for conveying knowledge. Indeed, literature is knowledge. It is an eye-opener to the past, the present and the future. In spite of the fact that literature shares a lot with history owing to its reflective nature, a classical Greek critic, Aristotle, asserts that literature is more philosophical than history in that whereas history deals with the past, literature deals with even what might happen; the general and probable. Literary matter is therefore useful to historians, sociologists and philosophers. The psychological concepts of Oedipus and Electra complexes that derived from Sigmund Freud's study of literature with a view to understanding man have demonstrated that

literature may also be informative to psychologists. Indeed, it has been universally acknowledged that one cognitive value in drama and novels is the psychological. Through various studies of psychological writers like Euripedes, Sophocles, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Ibsen, Balsac, Tolstoy, Narayan and Ngugi wa Thiong'o, among others, literary critics have been able to show that literary writers may actually teach one about human nature as much as psychologists.

Literary matter also provides an inexhaustible source for folklorists. Literature is one of the best media for preservation and transmission of a people's cultural values. Literature helps to ensure that a people's way of life does not fade into oblivion. Some works of literature even go further and explore possible causes of cultural erosion and suggest ways of overcoming acculturation. Let me cite an example here. Francis Imbuga's novel

Shrine of Tears is a good example. In this novel, Imbuga explores the effect of western education, religion, tourism and music on African culture. On music, Imbuga suggests that instead of the western songs that our media houses seem to favour, our local broadcasting stations should air local music. He also recommends performance of more African-oriented plays in our theatres rather than the prevailing scenario where people seem to be obsessed with Euro-centric drama. Ngugi wa Thiong'o's and Chinua Achebe's works are good storehouses of African culture before the adulteration that came with western influence. These authors explore issues to do with: African marriages, naming ceremonies, validation of circumcision/initiation for both males and females, sources of polygamy in the African context, African communalism among other issues.

Another function of literature, inherent in its very reflective nature, is that of creating socio-political awareness and guiding morally by repudiating the wrong and approving what is right. It is in this sense that a South African writer and critic, Ezekiel Mphahlele, labeled the literary writer "a sensitive point" in his society. Henry James terms writers who turn a blind eye to social happenings as traitors of a noble course. Apart from learning about aspects of human nature, literary works are themselves directly educative to the readers on matters of social life and co-existence. Through literary works, morals may be imparted. For example David Mulwa's play ***Redemption*** has many teachings on morality. Mulwa explores the hypocrisy that

characterizes the present religious situation. We get to learn that some people no longer go to church for spiritual reasons. Rather, they see God's ministry as a quick way to the good life. Politically, by describing the political structures of his society, a literary writer is interested in whether these structures work for or against the majority. What this means is that the writer is interested in the welfare of the majority lowly rather than the few rulers. As Ngugi wa Thiong'o rightly puts it in his book entitled *Writers in Politics*, literary writers are like soldiers in a battlefield. They can either choose to fight for the oppressed majority or the privileged minority. And indeed, like a true brigadier for his people, Ngugi is more interested in how the political structures of his society affect the general citizen. In *Petals of Blood*, Ngugi derides evils such as corruption, exploitation and consequently, abject poverty, which he sees as offshoots of imperialism. Traditional African communalism has been abandoned. Individualism is the order of the day. This has led to a division in the society into social classes based on wealth: the highest class, the higher class, an upper middle class, a lower middle class, and the low class who are the majority. The low classed are treated like real scum of the earth. Ngugi argues that most of the country's wealth has been taken by the minority high class. Ngugi advocates for socialism as the best way of solving our economic problems.

By awakening our consciousness, then, literature defines the direction we take in our daily struggles. Christopher Claudwell sees literary art as a versatile process. To Claudwell, literature and society exist in a dialectical oneness. Hence, not only do social occurrences impact on literature. Rather, since literature also inculcates attitudes and stirs our emotions, then literature also influences the direction society takes. Indeed, the universal existence of censorship attests to the fact that literature is not a mere reflection of reality but a potent art capable of directing attitudes that may motivate action.

Literature instills and perpetuates cultural values. In other words, literature plays the role of transmission of cultural values from one generation to another. In the traditional set-up, these values would be transmitted orally through folktales, proverbs, songs and riddles among other genres of oral literature. Present day children grow up in a society where the traditional set-up has been disrupted since they have to go to school and also majority of them grow up in urban setting. These urban children may learn a lot about their culture and history from literary works.

There is so much one may learn from Ngugi's novels about the history and traditional customs of the Agikuyu. Ngugi Wa Thiong'o deals with themes to do with: traditional socio-political setup, marriage customs, initiation rites, funeral rites, gender roles among many other themes. Literature therefore preserves the cultural values of a people. By its *connotative/implicative* nature, literary matter broadens people's minds. Literary works will not be understood only at the literal level. Good writers write in a manner that necessitates looking beyond the surface meaning. It is because of their connotative nature that literary works transcend the borders of their fictional worlds and epochs and may be applicable to many societies and generations. For example proverbs are imbued with facts that may infinitely remain relevant universally. Other genres of literature such as the novel and drama provide the audience/reader with conflicts/puzzling situations. Such conflicts / puzzles have always been the norm in human life. By letting us (the audience/reader) decide possible solutions to the dilemmas of life, such literary works enhance creativity on how to solve our problems.

Entertainment is a crucial function of literature. Even serious writers explore serious issues in an interesting way. Since a reader will not be compelled to read a literary text (unless it is a set text), judicious writers address serious themes in a pleasurable and appetizing manner. For example, Wahome Mutahi employs plenty of humour in articulating grave social issues. As one reads through his novel *Jail Bugs*, one is bound to laugh while taking note of the gravity of the overall message. Francis Imbuga employs idiotic or semi-literate characters in all his plays. The comic language of such characters is a great source of humour while at the same time satirizing absurd situations where for example either the illiterates or idiots (or both) are the rulers and therefore there is no hope for justice or the idiots are more reasonable than the sane. Mulili in *Betrayal in the City* and Agege in *Aminata* are such characters. The use of apt description, absurd situations, suspense, irony, symbolism, figurative language among other techniques, makes Ngugi's novels interesting to read. Certainly, literature is a great source of entertainment.

1.4 Summary

In this first lecture we have discussed the nature and function of literature. On the nature of literature we have looked at language and theme. We have noted that literary language is the main factor that distinguishes literature from other types of art. We have also observed that literary language is highly connotative and emotional. Thematically, literature is highly mimetic – reflective of social happenings. As regards the role of literature, we noted that literature entertains and teaches at the same time. As a source of information, literature is an eye-opener in many regards – historically, politically, culturally, morally, etc.

1.5 Activity



What is the function of literature? Illustrate from any literary works of your choice.

LESSON TWO POETRY

2.0 Introduction

In this second lecture we will begin with the oldest genre of literature – poetry. This is our first lecture in a series where we will look at various aspects of poetry. In this lecture, we will define the term *poetry* and investigate its genesis. We will then seek to understand and differentiate various forms of poetry.

2.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define the term 'poetry'.
2. Describe the thematic structure and scope of a poem.
3. Distinguish and describe various types of poetry.

2.2 What is Poetry?

The term *poetry* has been defined in many ways. Classical critics like Plato and Aristotle used the term to refer to imaginative literature in general. Samuel Taylor Coleridge defined poetry as “the best words in the best order”. Poetry has also been defined as the art of using language figuratively to convey one’s feelings or emotions. To others, poetry is a genre that has words selectively and carefully chosen to communicate ideas. Olembo (1986) sees a close relationship between poetry and music. This view tallies with Babette Deutsch’s (1965) definition: The art which uses words as both speech and song to reveal the realities that the senses record, the feelings salute, the mind perceives, and the shaping imagination orders. (p.111). Whereas Deutsch combines the structural and sensual qualities of poetry, Wordsworth is more interested in the imaginative expression of strong feelings, the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings inherent in poetry.

Looking at the definitions given above, you will note that certain words, certain qualities, certain ideas stand out. These words are: creativity/imagination, thought, truth, orderly arrangement, sense impression, beauty and rhythm. These words point the way to three qualities common to all poetry: content (a particular idea), form (that poetry has a definable structure) and thirdly, poetry is intended at a specific effect.

Having looked at the few definitions, however, we still need to agree on a definition that incorporates all the vital aspects mentioned.

In a nutshell, a poem is a self-contained literary composition in verse, either oral or written, usually short and compact, short enough to be read at a sitting, characterized by the presence

of creativity, emotion, truth in semiological and concrete language. Poetic language is purposely ordered to foreground the sound effects. This is because poems are meant to be spoken or sung: they are a form of heightened speech only that instead of being found in ordinary setting, poems are elevated to the regime of figurative language in order to enrich the normal manner of speech. That the phonological/sound aspects of a poem are made to stand out means that a poem ought to be read aloud in order to recognize these patterns and thereby be able to relate these patterns to meaning.

Poetry is the oldest form of all literary forms. It existed in all societies of the world since time immemorial. However, no literary historian can authoritatively point to the beginning of poetry. The earliest poems to be recorded in print form are from the holy scriptures. For example the *Psalms* and *Songs of Solomon* are recorded in the bible many years before Christ was born. Although some western critics have argued that there was no poetry in Africa prior to the coming of the white man to the continent, folkloric study has proved that Africa was not *groping in the dark* to the extent of not indulging in poetry. There were (and indeed there still are) many situations in which poetry was sang or recited in traditional African society. These studies show that Africa too had professional poets. A case in point is the *griot* of the West African Mande. The *griot* was traditionally a court poet attached to the king and his role was to compose and recite or sing poems about the king's achievements, about historical events surrounding the royal family etc. Such court poets were also found among the Ashanti of Ghana, the Zulu of South Africa and the Rwandese, among others. Apart from court poets, traditional African societies also had the freelance poet who was more diverse than the court poet in terms of thematization of his poems. The wayside poet was also another kind of freelance poet. We shall not delve into the subject of oral poetry in this lecture. An aspect of this will be tackled when we discuss oral poetry much later on.

Thematically, poems crop from a single emotion. They capture the emotion accruing from an experience, incident or a thought. What this means is that, unlike other literary genres like the novel and drama, poems are devoid of a story line. They are simply an ordered spontaneous outburst of sentiments recollected in calmness. 'Ordered' implies that as much as poetry derives from some spontaneous emotion, the writer endeavours to present this emotion in a pleasurable

manner by properly *arranging* the emotion through employment of linguistic decoration/ornamentation. ‘Tranquil’ because the poet tries to objectify his feelings so that his art does not become a mere sensual outburst lacking in both objectivity and creativity. An example here would suffice. Let us look at the following poem by Oswald Mtshali:

An Abandoned Bundle The morning
mist
And chimney
Of white city Jabavu
Flowed thick Yellow As
pus oozing
From a Gigantic sore

It smothered our little houses
Like fish caught in a net Scavenging dogs
Draped in red bandanas of blood
Fought fiercely
For a squirming bundle

I threw a brick,
They bared fangs
Flicked velvet tongues of scarlet
Leaving a mutilated corpse –
An infant dumped on a rubbish heap – “Oh!
Baby in the manger Sleep
well
On human dung”.
Its mother
Had melted into the rays of the rising sun, Her
face glittering with innocence
Her heart as pure as untrampled dew

Oswald Mtshali objectifies his detestation of the evils of urbanization through use of concrete images. More particularly, note the use of figurative language and a rationalizable sarcastic tone in castigating the iniquity of urban girls of throwing new born babies into pits simply because they had not planned for these babies. These girls do not care that vagrant hungry hounds may even eat up the abandoned babies.

The subject of this poem demonstrates clearly that poetry is a form of communication between the poet and his fellow human beings. Owing to the brevity of the genre, the poet only captures crucial, powerful and intense moments of human experiences.

2.3 TYPES OF POETRY

From a wider perspective, there are two common types of poetry which can further be sub-divided into smaller more specific categories.

2.3.1 Narrative poetry

A narrative poem tells of an event or a series of events. Incidents deriving from the ordinary business of living, its ups and downs, provide material for narrative poetry. This should not be mistaken to mean that narrative poems only aim to preserve an incident of human interest. Narrative poems do not merely contain but shape and re-organize the *historical* accounts.

Whereas the narrative element is quite prominent in prose, in poetry it tends towards concentration such that the same event or incident told by a novelist would be a great deal shorter in a poem. This is because while a prose fiction writer endeavours to convince his readers through accumulation of detail and thus create an illusion of reality, the poet tries to persuade and convince by the sharpness of detail chosen. Condensation in poetry has the advantage of creating a sense of immense intensity than is found in prose fiction.

Narrative poems may be simple or complex, long or short. Thus we have different types of narrative poems, namely: epics, ballads and metrical romances. These shall be looked at comprehensively in our third level poetry course. However, we shall briefly define and describe these types here:

- (a) Epic

An epic is a long (usually) narrative poem that recounts, in elevated style, the heroic deeds of a legendary person. Most epics originate in oral folk tradition. Good examples of modern African epics include: “Nyerere and Africa” and “Shaka”.

(b) Ballad

This is a simple and short narrative poem composed to be sung. The theme of most ballads is romantic. The language is usually simple, characterized by rhyme and repetition.

(c) Metrical Romances / Romantic Epics

Metrical romances are poems that recount gallant or courageous tales in verse. These poems were strictly metred. Romantic epics were also known as *Romances*.

2.3.2 Descriptive poems

Just like the narrative poems, descriptive poems too deal with the natural, perceptible world; hence, their subject is the human being. However, descriptive poems encompass a livelier sense of world through employment of evocative, concrete and clear images of sight, smell and sound. The intensity of these images makes the images stand out in isolation. This foregrounding of an image sets the reader thinking about its significance. Most importantly, the isolated image, derived from nature, usually carries some weight; has evocative power that transcends the literal significance of the image in the natural world. What this means is that the deliberate foregrounding of an *ordinary* item helps emotionally elevate the item to *extra-ordinary* levels. The reader or listener is jerked into asking why the poet selected that image and not any other. This way, the audience is compelled to think about its significance at all levels.

Types of poems which demonstrate this kind of subjectivity, imagination, emotion and also melody (some descriptive poems are written to be sung) include: lyrics, odes, sonnets and elegies.

(a) Lyric

This is a poetic device that expresses the writer's personal feelings and thoughts in the form of a song. Subjectivity, that is, personal expression of an individual's emotion, is therefore a significant element of the lyric form. However, the term *lyric* has also been ascribed broad and all inclusive elements making it an umbrella term for numerous sub-classifications that include: hymns, sonnets, songs, ballads, odes, elegies and *vers de societe*.

(b) Ode

The Ode is a lyric form that is elaborate, exalted and enthusiastic. *Elaborate* in the sense that it deals extensively with a single theme. *Exalted* because it is expressed in highly dignified language. *Enthusiastic* because it is sincere, imaginative and intellectual in tone. The ode form was originally composed to be sung. Of all lyrical poems, the ode exhibits a more complicated form. It is divided into three major parts called *strophes*. The word *strophe* simply means *turning point*.

In the performance of the Greek ode, the first part simply called *strophe* would be sung as the chorus moved to one side. The next turning point christened *antistrophe* would be sung while the chorus reverted back to the starting point. Finally, the last turning point labeled the *epode* would be sung while the singers simply stood still.

(c) Sonnet

A sonnet is a lyrical rhyming poem made up of fourteen iambic pentameter lines (lines composed of a rising meter made up of ten syllables of alternating five stressed and five unstressed). The sonnet has two major divisions: (i) an *Octave* – which consists of the first section of eight lines rhyming **abbaabba**; (ii) the *Sestet*, composed of the next six lines rhyming **cdccdc** or **cdccdc**.

While maintaining the fourteen iambic pentametered lines, the English sonnet exhibits four divisions. The first three divisions are made up of *Quatrains* or groups of four lines sharing a subject matter and rhyme scheme. The last two lines (usually rhyming) are called a *Couplet*. The couplet is habitually an epigrammatic close; a summarized

commentary on the three quatrains. The typical rhyme scheme for the English sonnet is: **abab cdcd efef gg**.

Apart from his famous tragic plays, William Shakespeare is also renowned for his sonnets. Look at the following example of a typical English sonnet by Shakespeare:

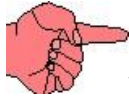
Let Me Not to the Marriage of True Minds

Let me not to the marriage of true minds
Admit impediments. Love is not love Which
alters when it alteration finds,
Or bends with the remover to remove O,
no! it is an ever-fixed mark
That looks on tempests and is never shaken; It is
the star to every wandering bark,
Whose worth's unknown, although his height be taken.
Love's not Time's fool, though rosy lips and cheeks Within
his bending sickle's compass come;
Love alters not with his brief hours and weeks, But
bears it out even to the edge of doom, If this be
error and upon me proved, I never writ, nor no man
ever loved.

(d) Elegy

An elegy is a poem or song of lament for the dead. An elegy is characterized by a persona's meditations of death of a particular person. In its generalized form, an elegy simply expresses a solemn mood. Good examples of elegies include: "Death of my father" by Henry Indangasi (*Poems from East Africa* - ed. Cook and Rubadiri) and "Beloved of my Mother" by Okot P'bitek (*An Anthology of East African Poetry* – ed. A.D. Amateshe).

Note



While we may have the intellectual reasons to scientifically divide poetry into narrative and descriptive types, it is not essentially true that a poet will only employ one form. Poets are not content with one element. A conglomeration of several elements is indeed what a poet needs to provoke a particular reaction. However, normally one aspect preponderates over or outweighs the other. This has been the basis of our poetic divisions here.

2.4 Summary



In this lecture, we have elaborately defined the term *poetry*. We have noted that whereas poetry shares narrative and descriptive qualities with prose fiction, poetry employs fewer details, condenses the details while arranging them in a manner capable of powerful impact upon the audience. In this lecture, we have also endeavoured to distinguish several poetic forms.

2.5 Activity



With examples, compare and contrast different forms of poetry.

LECTURE THREE

POETIC STYLE

3.0 Introduction

Having defined what poetry is in the last lecture; in this lecture we will now start focusing on the style of poetry. We will begin by looking at the uniqueness of sound features in poetry. Style rather than theme is indeed what mostly differentiates one genre of literature from another. Every genre in literature employs certain devices only peculiar to that specific genre. However, many of these devices are now common to all the genres. This has been encouraged by the liberty the literary writer has been given to flout all kinds of rules of writing. Be that as it may, in this lecture and the next one, we will be more concerned with the most outstanding literary devices employed by poets; that is, elements that distinguish poetry from other genres. In a nutshell, we will be more interested with features that make poetry a heightened form of speech.

3.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define poetic/literary sound features in clear terms.
2. Identify the sound elements in a poem.
3. Account for/justify the use of these phonic features.

3.2 Sound / phonological features of poetry

Poems are composed to be recited or sung. Therefore a poet extensively exploits phonic (sound) potentials of language in his bid to communicate. It is in this regard that a poem resembles music. There is a deliberate “musicianly resonance in both the sounds and associations of words chosen” (Deutsch, B: 1965). This means

that a poem in print must be read aloud in order to not only be able to enjoy the songfulness of the poem but also in order to be able to relate these sounds to the theme of the poem. Classical English poems, the Japanese *tankas*, *haikus* and *rengas* and traditional kiswahili *mashairi* abundantly exploited the resources of meter and rhyme. With the current global movement towards free verse, modern English and Kiswahili poems may not manifest substantial exploitation of phonic items. This notwithstanding, free verse also endeavours to present poems as rhythmic units. Each line in a stanza is presented as a tone unit, each stanza a rhythmic blend. This means that no matter the amount of employment of phonic items, ultimately every poet attempts to present his poem as a cohesive rhythmic union.

Now let us identify and describe the types of phonic items that a poet might use and the reasons for employing these elements.

Alliteration

Sometimes called *head rhyme* or *initial rhyme*, alliteration is the echo or repetition of the initial or first sound of several words in a line. The identical sound may be a consonant or a vowel. A good example of alliteration is seen in the following stanza from Richard Ntiru's poem entitled "Rhythm of the Pestle":

Listen, Listen
To the palpable rhythm Of the
periodic pestle Plunging in
proud perfection Into the
cardinal cavity of maternal
mortar

In lines 2, 3, 4, there is the consonantal repetition of the sound 'P' in the words: 'palpable', 'periodic', 'pestle', 'plunging', 'proud', 'perfection'. In line 5 there is the consonantal alliteration of 'C' (sound 'k') in 'cardinal' and 'cavity'. In the last line there is repetition of the initial 'M' sound in successive words "maternal mortar".

A good example of vowel alliteration is in the following lines: Apt

alliterations artful aid is
Often an occasional ornament in prose
(Deutsch: 1965:13)

There is alliteration of the vowel ‘a’ in the first line and ‘o’ on the second line.

Like other phonic items in literature, alliteration is employed purposefully in order to enhance meaning. In our first example from Richard Nturu, the poet repeats the explosive sound ‘P’ and ‘C’ (read ‘K’) to create the effect of the movement of a pestle pounding grain in a mortar.

Onomatopoeia

This is a device which is used in poetry to describe words which imitate sound. For instance the word ‘pop’ imitates the sound of a small explosion; ‘thud’ is the sound of something heavy and soft falling. Words like ‘splash’, ‘swish’, ‘twinkle’, ‘drone’, ‘whistle’, ‘suck’, ‘cough’, ‘buzz’, ‘whirr’, and ‘sizzle’ suggest their meaning in their pronunciation.

In poetry, onomatopoeic words are not just *sound* words. In the hands of good poets, in an effort to relate sound to sense, the poet may use such words to create poems that carry meaning only in their phonic structure.

The term *onomatopoeia* has also been used to refer to sound symbolism which may not approximate a definite echo but which is powerfully suggestive of the meaning. These words are also called ***phonetic intensives*** owing to their suggestive sound quality. Words beginning with ‘Cr’ (i.e sounding ‘kr’) suggest hard breaking (e.g. crush, crash, crunch). Words with an extended “O” sound such as ‘gloom’, ‘moan’, ‘groan’, and ‘forlorn’ may suggest melancholy. Words with a short ‘i’ such as ‘dwindled’, ‘thin’, ‘imp’, ‘cheap’ ‘bit’ and ‘slim’ are associated with what is little. A broad ‘a’ often goes with large as in: ‘amass’, ‘surge’, ‘thunder’, and ‘barrage’. Words beginning with the sound ‘fl’ are commonly associated with quick movement (flap, flip, fly, flash) or moving light (flicker, flare,

flame). Words beginning with the sound ‘sl’ are generally associated with smoothness and wetness. For example: ‘slide’, ‘slime’ and ‘slosh’.

Some linguists accept the idea that front vowels, which result in high tones, suggest light, small or airy things and back vowels, which result in low tones, suggest dark, large and heavy things. Lines from Rudyard Kipling below illustrate this:

And the fenders grind and heave,
And the derricks clack and grate, as the tackle hooks the crate, And
the fall-rope whines through the sheave ...

Consonance

Consonance refers to the successive use of words in which the medial or final consonants of the stressed syllables agree but the vowels that precede them differ. For example: *sad-wed*, *bed-bored*, *dull-doll* and *pork-suck*. A practical example is seen in the repeated use of the consonant ‘n’ in the third stanza of David Rubadiri’s poem “An African Thunderstorm”. This consonance clearly brings out the effect of the excitement that characterizes an African village following signs of an impending thunderstorm (rain seen as a blessing):

In the village
Screams of delighted children
Toss and turn
In the din of the whirling wind
Women
Babies clinging on their backs Dart
about In
and out
Madly
The wind whistles by
Whilst trees bend to let it pass.

Note also how the author uses alliteration of the sounds ‘t’ and ‘w’ to enhance the State of excitement (‘t’ in ‘toss’, ‘turn’) but also to imitate the sound made by strong wind passing (‘w’ in ‘whirling’, ‘whistle’).

Assonance

Closely related to consonance is *assonance*. This is technical term in poetry that refers to the deliberate foregrounding of similar vowel constituents followed by different consonants in two or more stressed syllables. Note its employment in the first stanza of Thomas’s “Ballad of the Long-legged bait”:

The bows glided down, and the coast
Blackened with birds took a last look At his
thrashing hair and whale-blue eye; The
trodden town rang its cobbles for luck

Assonance is seen in the use of ‘bows’ (pronounce ‘baus’) and ‘down’, ‘took’ and ‘look’; ‘blackened’, ‘last’, ‘thrashing’, ‘hair’; ‘whale’, and ‘rang’; ‘trodden’ and ‘cobbles’.

Assonance is not important only in enriching poetic ornamentation and creating musical effect. In the afore-given example from Rubadiri’s poem “An African Thunderstorm”, the vowels ‘a’, ‘i’, and ‘e’ are used together with consonance to suggest the quick movement of the wind heralding a storm. The ‘i’ as in ‘wind’, ‘whistle’, ‘wing’ suggests quick encroachment of the wind. The nasal consonants *n/m/ng* as in ‘wing’, ‘wind’, ‘scream’, ‘turn’, ‘bend’, ‘rumble’, ‘tremble’, ‘smell’ and ‘smoke’ clearly bring out the underlying conflict between man and nature as man tries to adjust himself to the changes that nature brings.

Rhyme

‘Rhyme’ is a wide term that has been used by some critics loosely to refer to any kind of repetition of any sound - whether vowels, consonants or a combination of both. From that position of argument, alliteration has been labeled *initial rhyme* or *head rhyme*; assonance has been called near *rhyme* or *approximate rhyme*.

Consonance has also been called suspended or *oblique rhyme*. Deliberate repetition of a word has been termed *identical rhyme*. In that regard the repetition of the refrain ‘Atieno yo’ in Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye’s “A Freedom Song” or the repetition of the phrase “By this well” in Henry Barlow’s poem “The village well” would be considered *identical rhyme* in this school of thought.

These are rather wide, loose, amorphous and confusing definitions of the term ‘rhyme’ akin to simply calling lions, leopards, cheetahs and tigers *big cats* as if they do not have specific labels that easily help one fathom the exact cat being alluded to.

I will therefore limit my definitions here to specifics. Firstly, I embrace Holman’s (1972) definition in describing ‘rhyme’ in general terms as:

Similarity or identity of sound existing between accented syllables occupying corresponding positions within two or more lines of verse. The correspondence of sound is based on the vowels and succeeding consonants of the accented syllables, which must, for a perfect rhyme, be preceded by different consonants. (p.452/453)

From the above definition we can pick out key words that may help us easily identify rhyme in a poem and differentiate rhyme from assonance, alliteration, consonance and repetition. The key words are: “syllables”, “corresponding positions”, and “different consonants”. The word “syllable” implies that rhyme involves a consonant and vowel. This in itself disqualifies assonance, consonance, alliteration or repetition as rhymes in the strict sense of the word. “Corresponding positions” in the sense used in the quotation indicates that rhyme occurs at stipulated intervals. Once again, this disqualifies alliteration, consonance and assonance since these may range with relative freedom through various positions. Lastly, the idea of “different consonants” as in ‘lean’ and

‘mean’ or ‘sick’ and ‘pick’ clearly disqualifies repetition as rhyme. It means that there should be a consonantal aspect within the words that distinguishes them.

Now that we have clearly defined the parameters in which rhyme operates, we need to mention the types of universally acknowledged rhymes available. The universally accepted rhymes are essentially two: (a) internal rhyme and (b) end rhyme. Of these two, end rhyme is widely used both in modern English and Kiswahili poems. Pre-twentieth century English and traditional Kiswahili poetry employed both internal and end rhymes. But first we need to define these types of rhyme before going any further.

(a) Internal rhyme

Also referred to as ***Leonine rhyme*** (named after Leo of St. Victor who was considered a pioneer in employing them in English poetry) internal rhymes occur in the middle of stanzas in poems whose stanzas are clearly partitioned in two parts. The following shahiri stanza by Muyaka provides a good example:

Mwandani wako mwandani, ukitaka mfeeli,
Mtima utie kani, utumie yakwe mali,
Umuonapo haneni hakuregeza kauli,
Ha-shabihi ha-mithili, huyo ni wako mwandani.

In this stanza we see use of internal rhymes at regular intervals in the following words in the first three lines: “mwandani”, “kani” and “haneni”. All these words end with the syllable ***ni***. The following stanza from Tennyson is an example of internal rhyme in English verse:

“Spanish ships of war at sea! we have sighted fifty three” Then sware
lord Thomas Howard: “ Fore God I am no coward But I cannot meet
them bare, for my ships are out of gear, And the half my men are sick.
I must fly, but follow quick We are six ships of the line; can we fight
with fifty three”

In the second to the fourth lines of this stanza there is consistent use of internal last syllables that rhyme with the final syllable in second part of the lines: “Howard” and “coward”, “here” and “gear” and “sick” and “quick”.

In the Kiswahili and English examples given, we note that in the final lines of both poems, the leonine rhyme or end rhyme or both internal rhyme and end rhyme are broken. This breaking of an established and outstanding rhyme pattern can be done in order to relieve the monotonous rhythm created by the rhymes. As the cliché goes, too much of anything is seldom good.

(b) End Rhyme

End rhymes occur at the end of a verse. In the Kiswahili stanza given before, there is the rhyming of the syllable *li* at the end of the stanza. A similar patterning of similar terminal sounds in a poem constructed in English can also be seen in Imbuga’s poem “The Ugly Beauty”:

And saw her in my *dream*
 Across
 yesterday beauty *stream* The slow
 morning snail *walk*
Nudged
 my side and made me *talk*
 But
 for the smile of *mucus*
 On the smile of cotton soft *face* I
 would thee still, my *Grace* And
 shame our separation *curse*

In the example above, there is the rhyming of: *dream-scream*, *walk-talk*, *mucus-curse* and *face-grace*.

Rhyme is more than a mere decoration or prosodic feature (feature of poetic composition). Its function transcends simply creating pleasure through sense impression resulting from a regular sound echo. A good poet uses sound features to enhance meaning. The rhyming words are usually stressed and stand out prominently

as phonic items. The rhyming words also serve to unify and differentiate a stanza from another. An excellent example is seen in the poem “The Ugly Beauty” cited above. In the first stanza there is semantic affiliation of the rhyming words “dream” and “stream” in that whereas dreams are unreal, illusory, streams are ever flowing; the water does not remain at one place. Just like the waters of a stream, dreams come and go. Hence, the two images are associated with fleeting fantasy, inconsistency and impermanency. Imbuga perceives a relationship between the waters of a stream or dreams with beauty. None of these is constant or enduring.

In the last stanza, the rhyming words “mucus” and “curse” conjure in our minds something nauseating, detestable, therefore repulsive. On the other hand, the words “face” and “grace” underscore the fact of beauty. The argument here is that it is not the physical attractiveness of the face that constitutes beauty but the grace or elegance that the face carries.

Rhyme Scheme

A ***Rhyme Scheme*** is a pattern of rhymes discernible in a stanza or poem. To illustrate this, let us look at Alfred Lord Tennyson’s poem entitled “The Yew in the Grave yard”:

Old yew, which grapest at the stores
That name the underlying dead, Thy
fibers net the dreamless head,
Thy roots are wrapped about the bones.

The seasons bring the flower again, And
bring the firstling to the flock; And in
the dusk of thee, the clock Beats out the
little lives of men.

O not for thee the glow, the bloom, Who
changest not in any gale

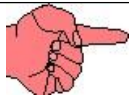
Nor branding summer suns avail To
touch thy thousand years of gloom.

And gazing on thee, sullen tree Sick
for thy stubborn hardihood, I seem
to fail from out my blood And grow
incorporate into thee

The rhyme scheme of this poem can be represented as **abba**. What this means is that, in all the stanzas, the last word of the first line rhymes with that of the fourth line. On the other hand, the last word of the second line rhymes with the last word of the third line.

This pattern is done consistently throughout the whole poem. However, we note a flaw in the fourth stanza where the words “hardihood” and “blood” in the second and last line only rhyme in writing but not phonologically (in sound) i.e **hadihud** – **blad**. The anomaly notwithstanding, there is careful use of semantically related words in the rhyme scheme. A case in point is the effective use of “stones”, “head”, “dead” and “bones” to allude to the theme of death.

Note



- 1) A true rhyme involves correspondence of sounds in accented syllables as opposed to unaccented syllables.
- 2) Syllables that have the same pronunciation but are spelled differently such as: **been** and **bean**, **keen** and **kin**, do not make acceptable rhymes.
- 3) For effectiveness of rhyme sounds, there should not be a long separation of the rhyming words. Such a long separation can only result in a loss of effect and also strain the audience’s attention.

3.3 Metre

The term *metre*, also spelled *meter* refers to the recurring rhythmic beat or pattern that obtains when there is organized, regular or almost regular occurrence of alternation of stressed and unstressed elements. The sonnet, a traditional English verse form is an excellent example of a tight metrical pattern. Let us look at the following example by Shakespeare entitled “No More Be Grieved”:

No more be grieved at which thou hast done, Roses
 have thorns, and silver fountains mud Clouds and
 eclipses strain both moon and sun, And loathsome
 canker lives in the sweetest bud. All men make faults,
 and even I in this, Authorizing thy trespass with
 compare,
 Myself corrupting salvaging thy amiss,
 Excusing thy sins more than thy sins are; For
 to thy sensual fault I bring in sense, Thy
 adverse party is thy Advocate,
 And ‘gainst myself a lawful plea commence, Such
 war is in my love and hate,
 That I an accessory needs must be,
 To that sweet thief which sourly robs from me.

As you can see from this example, sonnets have fourteen lines divided into three groups composed of four lines each (quatrains). Conventionally, quatrains represent unified and independent syntactic units. As you may have noticed from the example given, the first four lines focus on the harmony of life where *good* and *bad* exist side by side. There is a fresh change of tone and theme in the next four lines where the persona moves from generalities to specifics of “you” and “I”. In these lines, Shakespeare focuses on a specific theme of the complexity and opposition of emotions. However, theme is not our focus here. Let us look at the rhythmical pattern of the poem. Looking at every line, you will notice that each line has a total of ten syllables. Let us pick out one line and see:

x / x / x / x / x /

That I an accessory needs must be

The different stress marks indicate that not all the ten syllables are stressed.

X signifies the unstressed/ unaccented syllable while **/** marks the stressed syllable.

Looking at the poem, it is apparently clear that there is a regular alternation of stressed and unstressed syllables which create a mathematical beat, making the poem very musical. There are five stressed and five unstressed syllables in each line. Such a distribution is what we call in literary terms ***Pentametre***. A pentameter consists of five ***feet***. A ***foot*** in literary terms consists of one stressed/accented syllable and one or more unaccented syllables. There are five common English feet in English poetry namely: ***iambic***, ***trochee***, ***anapest***, ***dactyl*** and ***spondee***.

(a) Iambic Meter

An ***Iambic*** is a foot of two syllables in which the first syllable is short and unaccented and the second syllable long and accented. This means that an iambic meter is a ***rising*** meter. There are two major kinds of metre: the ***rising*** and ***falling*** metre. A good example of iambic metre can be seen in Shakespeare's Sonnet cited where all the lines begin with an unaccented element and end with a stressed element. This is the most common type of meter used in English poetry. Closely related to the iambic is the ***anapestic*** meter.

(b) Anapestic Meter

If in the iambic metre the stressed syllable is preceded by only one unaccented syllable, in the ***anapestic*** metre the stressed element is preceded by two unstressed elements. The folk ballad "The wife of Usher's Well" combines the iambic and the anapestic in the first, fourth, eighth and twelfth stanzas:

x / **x** / **x** / **x** /
 There lived a wife at Usher's well **x**
x / **x** / **x** / And a wealthy wife was
 she;
x / / / **x** / **x** /

She had three stout and stalwart sons,
x / x / x /
And sent the oer the see

x / x / x / x /
And she has made to them a bed,
x / x / x /
She's made it large and wide
x x / x / x / x /
And she's taen her mantle her about,
/ / x x / /
Sat down at the bed-side

x / / x / x / The
cock hadna crawd but once, x / x
/ x /
And clappd his wings at a'
x x / x / x / x /
When the youngest to the eldest said,
/ x / / x /
“Brother we must awa”

/ x / x / x /
“Fare ye weel, my mother dear!
/ / x / x /
Fareweel to barn and byre!
x / x / x / x /
And fare ye weel, the bonny lass
x / x x / x /
That kindles my mother's fire!”

This is a good example of a rising meter. However, you will notice that in the second line of the first stanza, the first two syllables are unaccented. The same thing happens in the third line of the second and third stanzas. In the last stanza, the anapestic meter is employed in the words: “kindles my mother's...”.

(c) Trochaic Metre

Trochaic metre operates exactly opposite of the iambic metre. This means that a *trochee* is a foot of two syllables of which the first is strong or accented and the second weak or unaccented. A trochaic metre is therefore a *falling metre*. The first line of the last stanza of the folk ballad above exhibits this.

(d) Dactylic Metre

Closely related to the trochaic metre, the dactylic is a metrical foot of three syllables in which the first is strong and the other two, short and unstressed.

William Butler Yeats' poem "A Deep Sworn Vow" demonstrates this in the first and last lines. In spite of this, the poem is irregular in its metric pattern in that the lines reveal a combination of trimeter, tetrameter and pentameter:

/ x x / // / // /
 Others because you did not keep
 x / // / x x / x /
 That deep sworn vow have been friends of mine
 // / // / // // / x //
 Yet always when I look death in the face
 x x x / / x / x / When
 I clamber to the heights of sleep, x / x
 / x / x x /
 Or when I grow excited with wine,
 x x x // // //
 Suddenly I meet your face.

(e) Spondaic Meter

This is a metrical foot consisting of two stressed syllables. This form is rare in English and Kiswahili verses since most of the polysyllabic words (words with many syllables) have a primary accent. In Kiswahili, the accent is predictably on the penultimate (second last) syllable however long the word. Spondaic feet are generally composed of two monosyllabic words such as: *all-day*, *death-trap*, and *bright-day*.

Importance of Metre

Although meter is only used to limited degrees by our modern poets who now prefer to write freely without being constrained by traditional modes, meter can be of great value to a writer especially in terms of demonstrating some symbolic rhythmic movement. Meter appeals to our very sensibility because of the rhythmicity it produces. It is indeed in the area of metre that poems resemble songs. A good poet does not employ metre just to produce some music effect or as mere decoration. He uses meter purposefully to enhance meaning. The metrical patterns of a poem ought to relate to the semantic aspects of the poem.

There are many other aspects of poetic composition such as: intonation, tempo, pitch and pause. However, this being an introductory course, we shall not delve into such elements. Owing to their *extra-literal* (non-written) manifestation, most of these features cannot be marked graphologically. They can only be heard. These elements will be dealt with comprehensively and extensively in our third level poetry course. However, we need to point out the general significance of phonic features, literal and extra-literal.

3.4 Rhythm in Poetry

Save for the specific function mentioned with regard to the assortment of sound features, the general cumulative effect of phonic items is in the creation of rhythm. Be that as it may, you may have noticed that our sub-title here reads “Rhythm in Poetry”. This implies that contrary to popular view of the term ‘rhythm’, rhythm is not the preserve of poetry and music. But first let us define *rhythm*.

The word *rhythm* is derived from a Greek word *rhuthmos* which means to *flow*. In Phonetics and prosody (poetic composition or versification), *rhythm* is generally described as the pattern of stressed and unstressed elements in language. With regard to the term, the Webster’s dictionary also emphasizes on the recurrence of alternation of strong and weak elements in the flow of sound. However, these two definitions are limited in as much as they define the term rhythm only in relation to phonological and linguistic aspects. Rhythm is also realized at the extra-linguistic level. However, that is beyond our present province of concern.

Looking at the definitions above, you will notice two key words: *flowing* and *regular*. These suggest that the essence of rhythm is in *flowing*, thus movement and the flowing occurs with certain *regularity*. Literature is a mirror of a nature that is rhythmical in its orientation. The rhythm that is rampant in literature is therefore reflective of the day-to-day life of man. Thompson, D. (1974) asserts that the sense of rhythm in man developed from his necessarily living by the rising and setting of the sun and change of seasons. Thompson challenges us to listen to the sounds of the wind, rain and animals around us. They are rhythmical. Rhythm is as old as man and it is inbuilt in our systems. Man seems to have a basic need for regularity of occurrence. Feel your heart beat, check your walking, breathing, talk. All these have a pace. Think of our country folks who would rather dig their farms in harmony of the movement of their hoes. A work song may be crooned to further enhance this harmony. What about the Jua kali (self- employed) metal or wood artisans hammering with certain regularity or the second hand cloth vendors singing “Ni ya leo, mali yaleo” to attract their customers while at the same time warding off the boredom and fatigue attendant to their vocation? Man is indeed inherently rhythmical. Since literature is a reflection of man’s day-to-day life, then it is inconceivable for literature to negate rhythm.

Rhythm is more marked in poetry than in any other literary genre. In poetry, rhythm is a product of a combination of sound features such as: onomatopoeia,

alliteration, consonance, assonance, rhyme, tempo, meter, stress, intonation, pitch and repetition.

In whichever genre of literature, rhythm is employed to enhance the meaning of the literary composition. It also lends both pleasure and heightened emotional response to the audience because it establishes a pattern of expectations and ultimately rewards him by satisfying his expectations. See how Henry Barlow moves our

emotions up and down by creating certain expectations through repetition of the phrase “By this well” in the poem “The village well”:

By this well,
Where fresh waters still quietly whisper As
when I
First accompanied mother and filled my baby gourd, By
this well,
Where many an evening it's clean water cleaned me;

This silent well
Dreaded haunt of the long haired Musambwa, Who
basked
In the mid-day sun reclining on the rock
Where I now sit
Welling up with many poignant memories;

This spot,
Which has rung with the purity of child laughter;
This spot,
Where eye spoke secretly to responding eye;
This spot,
Where hearts pounded madly in many a breast;

By this well,
Overhung by leafy branches of sheltering trees I
first noticed her.
I saw her in the cool of a red, red evening. I
saw her
As if I had not seen her a thousand times before.
By this well

My eyes asked for love, and my heart went mad. I
stuttered
And murmured my first words of love
And cupped,
With my hands, the intoxication that were her breasts.

In this well,
In the clear waters of this whispering well, The
silent moon
Witnessed with a smile our inviolate vows,
The kisses

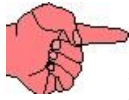
That left us weak and breathless.

It is dark.
It is dark by the well that still whispers. It is
darker,
It is utter darkness in the heart that bleeds By
this well,
Where magic has evaporated but memories linger. Of
damp death
The rotting foliage reeks, And
the branches
Are grotesque talons of hungry vultures, For
she is dead
The one I first loved by this well.

There is emotional build-up to a climax that comes at the end of the poem when we are told what exactly happened by the well. We get to learn of the death of the woman the persona loved and we are able to sympathize with the persona's predicament. In this regard, rhythm does not simply end at conveying the emotional weight of somebody's experience. The rhythm also makes us *share in* and *feel* the persona's experience. In fact, the rhythms of poems enact the various shades of emotions such as awe, hatred, pity, and love that are embedded in an experience. If effectively used, these rhythms will enable the reader or listener possess the emotion as if it were his own. He will therefore cry and laugh with the

persona as if he were actually the one involved in the experience. That is how powerfully good use of rhythm may work in a literary work.

Note



In poetry, the rhythmic pattern is more often established by a combination of phonological (sound) and non-phonological features.

3.5 Summary



In this lecture we have looked at the language of poetry at the level of sound. We have analysed key phonic elements such as: consonance, assonance, alliteration, rhyme, meter and onomatopoeia. We have demonstrated that these items not only enhance the rhythmicity and colour the tone of a poem but also enhance the meaning of a poem by facilitating comprehension of the import of a feature. Culminating in “rhythm”, we have noted that the rhythmic effects created by sound elements also serve to involve the listener or reader emotionally.

3.6 Activity

Read a poem of your choice aloud several times, trying to surrender to its natural rhythm. Do you think the sound features are effectively used?

LESSON FOUR

SENSE DEVICES IN POETRY

4.0 Introduction

This is the fourth lecture in this course. In the third lecture we looked at the sound constituents of a poem. Sound elements on their own cannot make much meaning. Writers also combine such components with sense devices. In this lecture we shall look at sense tools and their significance in poetry.

4.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define a sense device.
2. Identify a sense device and describe its manifestations.
3. Give reasons for the use of sense devices in poetry.

4.2 Sense Devices

Just as the word *sensuous* suggests, sense devices allude to techniques of language manipulation that only appeal to our emotions through the careful creation of certain mental pictures and images. Our minds and feelings can only be stimulated when concrete particulars rather than abstract pictures are used.

Sense devices affect meaning in so many different ways. By comparing things, as it is done in metaphors or similes, the similarity or difference in sense devices renders the matter in question a lot easier to comprehend. Depending on the shade of emotion a comparison elicits, the comparison also brings to the sense tools some form of emotional heightening. Sense devices include: metaphors, metonymy, synecdoche, similes, irony, sarcasm, tropes and symbols. we will

define some of these devices and evaluate their importance in poetry.

(a) Metaphor

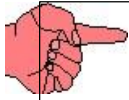
Aristotle defines the term *metaphor* thus:

Metaphor consists in giving the thing a name that belongs to something else; the transference being either from genus to species, or from species to genus, or from species to species, or on ground of comparison ... That from analogy is possible whenever there are four terms so related that the second (B) is

to the first (A), as the fourth (D) to the third (C); for one may metaphorically put D in lieu of B, and B in lieu of D.

In simple terms, metaphor is a figure of speech that consists in covert or indirect comparison. It is implied analogy which creatively ascribes to one thing the quality of another thing without verbalizing the grounds for comparing the two things. Therefore, A becomes B and B becomes A. The indirect comparison in a metaphor hinges on investment of transferable emotional or imaginative qualities. Thus, metaphors entail interactive implicit suggestiveness. That is, while remaining distinct, the compared elements draw out and emphasize certain implications of each other while ignoring or suppressing the irrelevant attributes.

Note



The referential and emotive significance of the things being compared in sense devices is to represent a truth which can only be communicated through the analogy.

In *Principles of Literary Criticism*, I.A. Richards comes up with two important terms to clarify the essence of a metaphor. These terms are: (a) **tenor** and (b) **vehicle**. Richards understands metaphors to be an interaction of tenor and vehicle. He defines **tenor** as the principal idea or subject of comparison. **Vehicle** is the figure or image employed to convey the subject communicated. For example when Jonathan Kariara says:

A leopard lives on a Muu tree
Watching my home
My lambs are born speckled My
wives tie their skirts tight Fearing
mottled offspring ...

The tenor here is adultery, the vehicle is the leopard, conveyed through use of animal imagery. There is careful choice of vehicle to bring out the tenor. Just like a leopard survives by preying on other animals around it, the perfidious man who is in the habit of cuckolding the persona and in the process producing *speckled lambs* and *mottled* offspring, is a relative of the persona.

The following two lines from Shakespeare's Sonnet 2 should also provide a good illustration:

When forty winters shall besiege thy brow And
dig deep trenches in thy beauty field.

The tenor here is aging. The vehicle is a season of the year (winter) and the image of besieging soldiers. Shakespeare suggests a similarity between wrinkles brought by old age and the ditches dug by besieging soldiers.

Having clarified the essentials of a metaphor, what is the use of metaphor in poetry?

According to Aristotle:

Metaphor ... gives style clearness, charm and distinction as Nothing else can: and it is not a thing whose use can be taught by one man to another.

The view we garner from this quotation is that metaphoric language enlivens poetic style. Therefore, to Aristotle, metaphors are necessary in as far as stylistic ornamentation is concerned. This view is true but limited in the sense that it does not touch on the thematic use of metaphors. Veritably, metaphors issue from more complex interactions of perceptions, feelings and thoughts than a mere eye for resemblances (the only aspect classical Greek philosophy emphasized). As we have seen from the two examples cited, metaphors may function as the controlling image

of a whole text thereby elevating the images to a pedestal higher than mere semblance. In that regard, the metaphors become the life, the very heart of that text without which the text would literally die and may be rendered meaningless. Therefore, apart from decorating a literary work and thereby making it appealing to read or listen to, metaphors also serve to:

- (i) make the meaning clear through the principle of transference of meaning. For example in Gabriel Okara's poem "Once upon a time", the use of the metaphoric phrases "laugh with their hearts" and "laugh with their teeth" clearly expresses the difference between genuine relationships and pretentious ones.
- (ii) Secondly, metaphors serve to make the meaning forceful. In Kariara's "A leopard lives on a Muu tree" cited earlier, the persona employs metaphoric phrases to forcefully bring out the idea of a kin betraying him by taking advantage of his impotence to prey on his wives. Phrases such as "my sword has rusted in the scabbard" and "the upright post at the gate has fallen" effectively draw our attention to the fact that the persona is sexually dysfunctional and therefore very frustrated.
- (iii) When metaphors make the meaning forceful, they become powerful enough to elicit all shades of emotions. In Kariara's poem alluded to above, we sympathize with the persona while berating the lecherous, traitorous kin. In Laban Erapu's "The Guilt of Giving" the use of metaphors like "... heap of rags that pollute the air conditioned city centre" helps reflect on the inhumanity of the city dwellers who have no feelings for the suffering beggars pervading their cities. Subsequently, the audience develops some bitterness towards the unfeeling urban populace.
- (iv) By arousing emotions, consequently metaphors will inculcate certain attitudes in a reader or listener. Ultimately the audience will have been influenced to take a particular stand in as far as the experiences delineated in the poem are concerned.

Note

Because of their implicit nature, metaphors are economical and also more open-ended than similes in terms of interpretation. This means that metaphors can be understood variably yet correctly.

(b) Simile

A simile is a figure of speech in which something is said to resemble another with regard to certain specific attributes. In a simile, the basis for comparing is explicit rather than implicit. This means that the ground for analogy is clearly verbalized. Therefore whereas a metaphor states that A is B or B is A, a simile states that A is like B or B is like A. A simile would therefore succinctly be defined as a figure of speech in which analogy between two objects is overtly expressed. Let's get an example from Gabriel Okara's "Once Upon a Time":

So I have learnt many things,
I have learned to wear many faces Like
dresses – home face,
Office face, street face, host face, cocktail face,
With all their conforming smiles Like a fixed
portrait smile.

In this fourth stanza of the poem "Once Upon a Time", Okara employs similes and other images to bring out the idea of hypocrisy of adults who are seldom sincere with their feelings. Okara's argument is that most of their adult life, grown-ups engage in sheer enactments akin to theatrical performances. The similes "many faces like dresses" and "conforming smiles like a fixed portrait smile" clearly illustrate the tenor of pretence.

From the example above we note a very important aspect of similes – the use of specific words "like" or "as" in order to verbalize the exact aspect of analogy. This

means that a simile differs from a metaphor in the sense that the tenor and vehicle in a simile are identified as such and the essence of their resemblance is clearly denoted by the use of “as” or “like”.

Due to their directness, similes are less evocative than metaphors in the sense that similes are *closed* – that is, the interpretation of the comparison cannot go beyond the theme of analogy. Hence a simile is limited in its semantic scope. However, like all other figures of speech, similes are important in poetry in terms of making meaning clear, forceful, arousing emotions, inculcating attitudes and colouring the tone of a literary text. Similes like “He is as blind as a bat” or “as stupid as a mule” clearly bring out the aspect of blindness or foolishness by emphasizing these aspects through analogy. A simile like “He is as cunning as a fox” will definitely instill the idea that he is not to be trusted.

Whereas the metaphor and simile are the most common types of sense devices, they are not the only ones. we will now discuss other sense devices.

(c) Symbol

Charles Chadwick (1971) defines symbolism as:

the art of expressing ideas and emotions not by describing them directly, nor by defining them through overt comparisons with concrete images, but by suggesting what these ideas and emotions are, by recreating them in the mind of the reader through the use of unexplainable symbols. (p.2/3)

Therefore symbols consist in signifying a reality that transcends the referent. They evoke an objective reality with the sole aim of having that reality intimate another level of meaning. What this means is that symbols do not represent the meaning itself. Rather, symbols are images in as far as they evoke a referent that suggests multiple meanings and feelings associated with the referent. In that regard therefore, symbols elicit notions and emotions which make the symbol comprehensible. A symbol is open-ended. Whereas water may be seen as a symbol of purity in religious circles, it may be a symbol of death to others (Read Hemingway’s *A Farewell to*

Arms). A snake may be a symbol of danger and evil among certain people, but to others, it is a symbol of blessing, charm, it is beauty itself, it is a delicacy.

A symbol differs from a metaphor in that whereas a metaphor points to an object in order to illustrate an idea or show a quality, a symbol contains the idea or quality.

(d) Personification

This is a sense device or figure of speech which attributes human form and character or sensibility to non-human things. Animals, inanimate objects, even abstract ideas are made to behave like a person: they can laugh, talk, sing, think, walk, feel and do many other things that a human being can do.

Personification is also called *Prosopopeia* in literary language.

A good example of personification can be seen in Jared Angira's poem entitled "The Slum":

Night steals in unnoticed
And spreads a thick black buibui Over
the slum where the street lights Are in
conception
And the slum begins to roar.

A number of things have been personified here. There is personification of the night being capable of *stealing* and *spreading* "a thick black buibui" just as a man would spread a blanket over a bed or draw the curtains to cut out the light. There is also the personification of street lights being in "conception" meaning that the idea of having street lights in the slums is just that – an idea in the minds of the planners. Lastly, the slum begins to "roar".

As you may see from the examples cited above, personification exhibits the same uses we noted with regard to the metaphor. The idea of night *stealing* clearly shows how darkness falls abruptly in the slums. The notion of street lights only being in conception serves to influence the audience's perception of the city planners who do not seem to care about the have-nots of this society. The activities that pervade the

slum at night such as prostitution, drunkenness and loud music emanating from bars selling illicit brews; activities that even involve bed bugs and lice that take advantage of the darkness to torment the slum dwellers and render them sleepless, cannot be described better than through the personification of *roaring*.

(e) Metonymy

This is a figure of speech in which an attribute of a thing or person substitutes the thing or person. A woman becomes merely a *Skirt*, hard labour becomes just *sweat*, Shakespeare's writing are simply designated by the writer's name. Other examples are as follows:

- (i) This land belongs to the crown
- (ii) Kamau is fond of the bottle
- (iii) Capital Hill fully supported the Gulf war.

In the first example, the crown is a metonymy for government. In the second example, the bottle is a metonymy for beer. In the last example, Capital Hill represents the place where the congress of the United States of America has its head quarters; therefore a metonymy for the American congress.

(f) Synecdoche

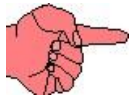
Closely related to metonymy is a *synecdoche*. In a synecdoche, a portion or part of a thing, animal or person is named with the intention of designating the whole. The whole is therefore comprehended from mentioning the part. The reverse is also true. The whole can be named to designate the part. For example:

- (i) This house was built by forty hands
- (ii) Kenya has some of the best brains in the continent.

- (iii) She died beneath the wave.
- (iv) Brazil beat Germany in the 2002 world cup.

In the first example, the synecdoche of *hands* stands for people. In the second example again the *brains* are not solitary brains but intelligent people. The *wave* in the third example is a synecdoche for the sea. The last one is an example of a synecdoche where the whole (Brazil and Germany) represent part (teams) and not the millions of Brazilians or Germans.

Note



- (i) Even though most of the sense devices we have discussed in this lecture fall under figures of speech, not all sense devices are figures of speech. But all figures of speech are imagery. Sense devices are essentially images. Whereas figures of speech are essentially realized at the linguistic level, other images can be realized at the extra-linguistic level.
- (ii) The sense devices discussed here are not the exclusive preserve of poetry. However, in this lecture we were more interested in their manifestations and significance in poetry.

4.3 Summary

In this lecture we have looked at different types of sense devices in poetry. We have pointed out that sense devices are images which are aimed at appealing to the reader's or listener's feelings, intellect and instinct. We have demonstrated that apart from colouring the tone of a poem, sense tools help in clarity, are forceful in their semantic impact; they are powerful enough to evoke our emotions and also powerful enough to make the reader take a certain stand.

4.4 Activity



Analyze the following poem, giving special consideration to its imagery.

Piano and Drums – Gabriel Okara

When at break of day at a riverside
I hear jungle drums telegraphing
the mystic rhythm, urgent, raw like
bleeding flesh, speaking of primal
youth and the beginning,
I see the panther ready to pounce, the leopard
snarling about to leap and the hunters
crouched with spears poised;

And my blood ripples, turns torrent,
topples the years and at once I'm In my
mother's laps a sucking; at once I'm

walking simple paths with no innovations,
rugged, fashioned with the naked warmth of
hurrying feet and groping heart in green
leaves and flowers pulsing.

Then I hear a wailing piano solo speaking of
complex ways in tear- furrowed concerto; of
far away lands and new horizons with
coaxing diminuendo, counterpoint,
crescendo. But lost in the labyrinth of its
complexities, it ends in the middle of a
phrase at a dagger point.

And I lost in the morning mist of
an age at a riverside keep
wandering in the mystic rhythm
of jungle drums and the concerto.

LESSON FIVE

STRUCTURE IN POETRY

5.0 Introduction

This is our fourth lecture in this course. In the last lecture we discussed sense devices as evinced in poetry. In this lecture we shall now move on to another aspect of poetry: the structure of poetry. We will be more interested in the structural patterns and tools either only found or uniquely used in poetry.

5.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define the word ***structure*** from a literary point of view
2. Identify types of structure
3. Relate structure to meaning

5.2 Structure

The term **structure** in literature means the planned physical and internal framework of a literary work. *Planned* because everything in a literary work in both form and content ought to be intentional and not accidental. A writer sets down to express certain issues in a particular manner. Therefore anything that appears to happen inadvertently both in structure or content may be singled out and cited as a literary flaw/weakness. A good writer organizes his literary strategies in such a manner that they would not only be attractive in the beauty and mastery of presentation; coherent and cohesive; but also powerfully effective in their emotional impact.

Since we have already discussed sound features, we will not repeat the exercise here. However, we will look at repetition as a unique structural device distinct from the phonic items discussed earlier.

5.2.1 Stanzaic or Verse arrangement

One of the features that distinguish poetry from other literary genres is the use of stanzas. A **Stanza** in poetry is a recurrent assemblage of more than one line. Such groups of lines are commonly of more or less equal length. In traditional poetry, such lines would also be metrically equal and often have a rhyme scheme.

However, with the less use of metric patterns and rhyme schemes in modern poetry, the partitioning into stanzas is in most cases done according to the form of stanza and most importantly, according to the idea being explored. What this means is that a stanza in poetry is conventionally presented as a single unit.

Another literary term for stanza is **strophe**.

In traditional poetry stanzas are named according to the number of lines. For instance a **couplet** has two lines, a **tercet** or **terza rima** has three, a quatrain has four, a **sestet** has six and an octave or **ottava rima** has eight lines. Most of these structures have specific rhyme schemes and metric patterns.

Note

While knowledge of the stanza type is imperative, it should be noted that a stanza form is not an end in itself. A stanza type is just a tool at the poet's disposal. The same tool may be used by another author for very different reasons.

Modern poets are not so keen about the number of lines in a stanza as to the unity of thought. The most common stanza types in modern poems are: mono-stanzaic, multi-stanzaic, rhetorical and deliberative statements.

Mono-stanzaic

Mono-stanzaic poems consist of a single stanza no matter the number of lines. Such poems tell a connected story. A good example is Jonathan Kariara's "A leopard lives in a Muu tree". Note also how J.P. Clark employs a single stanza to talk about the mythical child 'Abiku' who is born to die but continuously reappears into the same womb to torment the mother:

Coming and going these several seasons, Do
stay out on the baobab tree,
Follow where you please your kindred spirits
If indoor is not enough for you. True, it leaks
through the thatch When floods brim the
banks, And
the bats and the owls
Often tear in at night through the eaves,
And at harmattan, the bamboo walls Are
ready tinder for the fire
That dries the fresh fish up on the rack. Still,
it's been the healthy stock
To several fingers, to many more will be Who
reach the sun.
No longer then bestride the threshold But
step in and stay
For good. We know the knife scars

Serrating down your back and front
Like the beak of the sword-fish, And
both your ears, notched As a
bondsmen to this house,
Are all relics of your first comings. Then
step in, step in and stay For her body is
tired, Tired, her milk going sour
Where many more mouths gladden the heart.

Multi-stanzaic

Just as the word *multi* suggests, multi-stanzaic poems have several stanzas. They usually express diversity in theme. The stanzas also act as pauses in performance. These pauses are important in helping the mind take a break and digest the concerns of one stanza before moving on to the next one. A good example of a multi-stanzaic poem is Richard Nturu's poem "If it is true":

If it is true
That the world talks too much Then
let's all keep quiet
And hear the eloquence of silence.

If it is true
That the world sees too much Then
let's all close our eyes And see the
inner vision Beneath the closed
eyes.

If it is true
That the world hears too much Then
let's close our ears And
listen to the chastity of
Inner
music That defies betrayal
By the wayward, wind.

If it is true
That the world moves too much
Then let's stand statue still And
imitate the stubborn will Of
trees

That move without being peripatetic For
the dumb don't tell lies
For the blind cant be peeping-toms
For the deaf cannot eavesdrop For the cripples can't trespass.

Rhetoric stanzas

Rhetoric stanzas end by pausing a question to the reader. A good example is Everett Standa's "Wedding Eve":

Should I
Or should I not
Take the oath of love For
ever
This person I know little about?

Does she love me Or
my car
Or my future
Which I know little about?

Will she continue to love me When
the future she saw in me Crumbles
and fades into nothing Leaving the
naked me
To love without hope?

Will that smile she wears
Last through the hazards to come When
fate strikes
Across the dreams of tomorrow?

Or will she,
Like the clever passenger in a faulty plane,
Wear her life jacket
And jump out to save her life
Leaving me to crash into the unknown?

What magic can I use
To see what lies beneath

Her angel face and well knit hair
To see her hopes and dreams Before
I take the oath
To love forever?

We are both wise chess players She
makes a move I
make a move
And we rap each other in our secret dreams
Hoping to win against each other.

Declarative stanza

A declarative stanza is made up of a statement or statements. Taban Lo Liyong's long and varied poem "bless the african coups" has such declarative stanzas. Let us look at three of such stanzas:

the tragic is that which charts a counter or
un-course the
tragic is that which alters a people's whole concept of good
and evil
it is tragedy when overnight you are labeled a sinner it is
tragedy when your friends are out to hang
you it
is tragedy when your brother betrays you for fun or
fund it is
tragedy when darkness descends and you know it will
suffocate you

tragedy is the goats song when the
butchers knife is near
tragedy is the swans song when
death is around

5.2.2 Parallelism

Parallelism in literature is a structural device containing identical elements. These elements are conventionally similar in meaning or structure or both. However, if the word *parallel* also implies that the structures cannot meet, then, parallelism may also entail juxtaposition of opposite ideas. This occurs when two completely opposite

pictures are put side by side. For example: black and white, up and down, day and night. Sometimes the contrast is immediately obvious.

Sometimes the contrast is implied. We will now look at forms of parallelism:

(a) Stanzaic parallelism

This is where stanzas are structured in the same manner in all regards. A good example is Jared Angira's "Armanda"

(You will find this poem on page 117 in *Anthology of East African Poetry* – ed. A.D. Amateshe)

Richard Nturu's "If it is true" which was cited earlier is also an excellent example.

Note that each stanza is syntactically arranged in the same manner. Each of the stanzas begins with the conditional clause "If it is true" followed by "then ...".

(b) Characterological parallelism

This is where a poet or literary writer generally compares and contrasts two characters. A good example is Richard Nturu's "Twin Ceremony". (You will find this poem on page 90, *Anthology of East African Poetry*) In this poem, Nturu effectively contrasts an infant with a dead person.

(c) Attitudinal Parallelism

This is a kind of parallelism where the speaker's attitude contrasts or clashes with the reader's or listener's expectation. A good example is Henry Indangasi's "Death of my father". Whereas the reader's expectation is that one would mourn for his father, the persona in this poem does not mourn.

(d) Repetition

Poets often repeat single words, phrases, single lines, groups of lines or even whole stanzas, at intervals, for various reasons. The most obvious is to create a musical effect. Indeed, repetition enhances rhythm in a poem. It also contributes to the overall structure of the poem. The refrain "By this well" or "In this well" in Henry

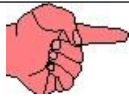
Barlow's poem earlier cited structurally marks the beginning of every stanza and ultimately leads us to the answer as to what exactly happened by the well. Such a repeated line will be clearly retained in the mind – long after the other lines are forgotten. And if such a line has emotive power, then repetition would have played its rightful role.

5.3 Poetic diction

The term *diction* refers to selection of words. The creative, accurate, careful use of these words in literary works makes good diction. Therefore, proper diction entails:

- (i) suitable choice of words for particular meaning(s) to be communicated.
- (ii) The use of refined vocabulary. This means that a literary writer should steer clear of obscenities and improprieties.
- (iii) Thirdly, good diction entails small, concrete, clear-cut words. In this regard, a literary writer is expected to avoid big and abstract words such as: neurotherapy, morphophonology, anti-establishmentarianism and the like.

Note



Diction alludes only to the choice of words employed in literary discourse. The arrangement and combination of these words is no longer diction but *style*.

5.4 Summary

In this lecture, we have looked at some structural devices employed in poetry. We began by defining the term *structure* in a literary sense. Then, we discussed

various stanzaic arrangements and explained the possible rationale for such arrangement. Lastly, we explained the notion of poetic diction.

5.5 Activity

Activity

With examples from any one of the following anthologies of poetry, discuss what we mean by *structure* in poetry:

- (i) Cook & Rubadiri (eds): *Poems from East Africa*
- (ii) Luvai (ed): *Boundless Voices: Poems from Kenya*
- (iii) Amateshe (ed): *Anthology of East African Poetry*

LESSON SIX

PROSE

6.0 Introduction

This lecture embarks on another genre of literature: *Prose*. We will deliberate on the various aspects of prose. Since prose is a subject as large as the poetry we discussed in the preceding lectures, the study of prose will take the next four lectures. While we will also look at the diverse literary prose forms available, we will concentrate more on fictional prose. Despite the fact that some of the things noted with respect to poetry and literature in general may also be relevant here, we will focus on the most tangible aspects of prose. We will look at how language is presented in fiction, aspects and types of fiction.

6.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

(a) define the term *Prose*.

(b) identify the characteristics of the Prose form.

6.2 What is “Prose”?

In its broadest understanding the term *prose* is ascribed to all written expressions which have a logical grammatical order and whose ideas are connectedly stated rather than merely stated. Whereas the definition applies to literary prose, we shall only be concerned with works that exhibit an additional element of conscious, cultivated writing. In all societies, prose as a literary genre developed more slowly than poetry. English prose is said to have begun in the ninth century. Unlike poetry which is composed for performance thereby foregrounding the sound patterns and effects, in prose the sound features are less marked and thus the rhythm has less regularity. This does not mean that prose is dull and linguistically insipid. Certainly, the term *prose* has often been associated with a style that is commonplace, unimaginative and uninteresting. However, literary prose is nowhere close to this. Undeniably, prose forms have been misjudged and analyzed wrongly due to the fact that unlike poetry which employs rather visible ingredients, the ingredients in prose are not easily visible even to an attentive reader.

Literary prose is characterized by a unique style and diction that separates it from any other prose form. Whereas it may be true that since prose forms are majorly composed to be read, they generally lack a regular rhythmic pattern, some prose writers employ sound effects akin to poetry. The speeches of the eloquent African American revolutionaries Martin Luther and Malcom X are excellent examples of what we call poetic prose. Charles Dickens is also one prose writer who employed a plethora and kaleidoscope of phonic items in his novels. See how repetition,

assonance and consonance enhance rhythm in the opening chapter of Dickens' *A Bleak House*. It almost reads like a poem:

Fog everywhere. Fog up the river where it flows among the
Green aits and meadows; fog down the river, where it rolls
defiled among the tiers of shipping, and the waterside
pollutions of a great (and dirty) city. Fogs on the Essex
marshes, fog on the Kentish heights.

The raw afternoon is rawest, and the dense fog is
Densest and the muddy streets are muddiest near that leaden,
headed old obstruction appropriate ornament for the threshold
of a leaden-heaped old corporation. Temple Bar. And hard by
Temple Bar, in Lincolns
Inn Hall, at the very heart of the fog; sits the Lord High
Chancellor in his High court of Chancery. (p.1/2)

Repetition of the words like *fog*, *temple*, *leaden* and *high*; the superlatives *rawest*, *densest* and *muddiest*; the use of alliteration in words like *chancellor-chancery*; consonance and assonance in words like *Essex-marshes*, undoubtedly enhance the phonological effects of this passage. Dickens also flagrantly violates grammatical rules to not only enhance the rhythmicity and therefore pleasurable of his novel but also to effectively communicate his theme. For instance, we have two-worded sentences like “fog everywhere” and “Temple Bar”. In the true sense of the word, these do not constitute *sentences*. A grammatical *sentence* ought to have a subject, object and verb. This is therefore a grammatical contravention. However, it serves well to increase the pace of the passage and, in so doing, effectively illustrate the confusion that prevailed in London following the industrial revolution.

The example from Dickens goes a long way in demonstrating that phonic features may also be prominently fruitful when employed in prose works. Indeed, it is

believed that a number of pre-twentieth century novelists such as Dickens wrote with a listening audience in mind.

Activity

Using any novel of your choice, describe the sound features used.

6.3 General characteristics of Prose

(a) Syntactic/graphological characteristics

Unlike poetry, which is written in verse, graphologically, prose is written in continuous sentences. These sentences are grouped into paragraphs depending on their topic or aspect of a topic. A writer may use simple one clause sentences or complex structures. The choice of which type of sentences to use purely depends on the different considerations at play. But some writers have what one may call an idiosyncratic preference for one type of sentence. For instance, Chinua achebe is renown for simple sentences. Dickens is renown for sentences even as long as one page. Look at the following example:

But when vague rumours got abroad, that in this protestant association a secret power was mustering against the government for undefined and mighty purposes; when the air was filled with whispers of a confederacy among the popish powers to degrade and enslave England, establish an inquisition in London, and turn the pens of a smith-field market into stakes and cauldrons, when terrors and alarms which no man understood were perpetually broached, both in and out of parliament, by one enthusiast who did not understand himself, and bygone bugbears which had not lain quietly in their graves for centuries, were raised again to haunt the ignorant and credulous; when all this was done, as it were, in the dark, and secret invitations to join the Great Protestant Association in defence of religion, life and liberty, were

dropped in the public ways, thrust under the house-doors, tossed in at the window, and pressed into the hands of those who trod the streets by night; when they glared from every wall, and shone on every post and pillar, so that stocks and stones appeared infected with the common fear, urging all men to join together blindfold in resistance of they knew not what, they knew not why; - then the mania spread indeed, and the body, still increasing every day grew forty thousand strong. (Dickens, C: *Barnaby Rudge*, ch. 7)

This is an excellent example of a complex sentence. Literary writers may use such sentences when they want to present the reader with a complex structure of ideas. The example above is what we call a *periodic sentence*. In this complex form, the writer withholds information, subordinates others until the end when he tells you the most important thing – “then the mania spread indeed, and the body, still increasing every day, grew forty thousand strong”. This structure has a series of *anticipatory clauses* (clauses that expect a main clause) that build into a climax thereby effectively describing the fomenting of the Gordon riots. The suspense created by the anticipatory elements indeed effectively dramatizes the growing fear that culminates in chaos.

Simple, short sentences may also have their advantages in literature. Look at the following example from Peter Abrahams’s novel *Mine Boy*:

The drill hummed. The hammer rang. There was a swish and a buzz and a hum, and there was the clang of the pick and grating of the shovel. And slowly the rhythm of the work gathered pace. Xuma smiled. He knew the rhythm. He controlled it. He kept at its pace ... (p.196)

In this example, Abrahams uses short crisp sentences to successfully bring out the pace of activity in the mines. Writers usually employ such short simple sentences made up mostly of monosyllabic words, at a climactic point in a novel.

Monosyllabic words and short sentences tend to move at a faster pace than

Multisyllabic words and long sentences. Short sentences and monosyllabic words are therefore effective in dramatizing moments of horror, awe, panic, anger and fear. Indeed, the dramatic power of short crisp sentences from *Mine Boy* cited above would be dissipated in a complex sentence. It would not have the same rhythm and impact in depicting the on-goings in the South African mines. Let's

look at the example again but this time trying to join up the sentences.

Slowly the rhythm of the work gathered pace as the drill hummed while the hammer rang and there was a swish, a buzz, a hum and the clinging of the grating of the shovel. Since Xuma knew the rhythm and controlled it, he smiled as he kept at its pace.

While the onomatopoeic words “hum”, “swish”, “buzz”, “clinging” still help to bring out the effect of action, the quick pace of the action is lost once we join the short sentences.

Graphologically (in print), long prose forms conventionally have divisions called *chapters*. A chapter is made up of a group of paragraphs that concentrate on a single effect or incident. In the longer prose forms such as the novel, some writers give their chapters a heading. Dickens does this very well in his novel *Hard Times*. His chapter titles have the effect of whetting the reader's appetite. Headings such as “Murdering the innocent” and “Filling the Pitchers” are curious headings that bring an element of suspense into the novel thereby compelling the reader to read on and see why and how the innocent children are psychologically murdered or what the empty pitchers really are (children) and what substance is being filled in them.

Most literary writers, however, simply number their chapters. This way, they do not want to influence their reader's expectations. Rather, they let their reader find out or decide what he or she thinks are the core concerns of that particular chapter. The notion of simply numbering a chapter without giving a clue through a heading may also be a good strategy for creating suspense especially if the preceding chapter created certain expectations that the reader expects to be fulfilled in the subsequent

chapter. For example, if events in the previous chapter pointed towards possibility of murder, the reader will be compelled to read the next chapter to see what happens. However, if the following chapter has a heading which is too telling and which contradicts the reader's expectations, a reader may not keep on reading the novel with the same enthusiasm.

Note

It is not a must that one reads a literary text unless it is a set book. Yet writers do not write with the sole aim of getting their works selected as set books. Not every literary matter can be set text anyway. Hence, a good literary writer develops pleasurable strategies that will *compel* a reader to read his work, the whole work, without feeling *coerced*.

(b) Phonological characteristics

Although we have noted that prose writers can also effectively employ sound features in their works, in its strictest basic form, prose, as a written text, does not have a phonological level as such. Nonetheless, this does not negate the truism that in its original form, a work of prose, essentially molded through language which has various levels, intrinsically must have phonological potentials. The sound effect of a spoken word cannot suddenly *die* when the spoken word is put in print. The implicit sound patterns and effects of written literature can always be brought to life, made explicit through reading literally aloud or reading *aloud silently*. In prose forms, the implicit phonological characteristics are determined by two main factors: the selection of words and the syntactic patterning of structures. The example from Peter Abrahams that was earlier cited would still suffice here. Abrahams carefully selects onomatopoeic words “swish”, “buzz” and “clang” to show the different types of sounds emanating from the mine. In

conglomeration, these sounds suggest a din, a confusion of sound. This is the kind of audio torture the miners have to endure every day.

As regards syntactic patterning, the most common form of style employed by writers at the sentence level operates on the principal of climax; where the most important information is given last. This is where the writer withholds information until the end of a sentence. The long sentence from Dickens' *Barnaby Rudge* that was earlier cited is a good example. Note that the climax of that sentence comes at the very end. There is a build-up of ideas leading to a main clause. The build-up of the subordinate clauses is indeed phonologically rhythmical. The sound effect of such a structure is realized when the sentence is read naturally with a rising intonation. A sentence must not necessarily be too long for phonological effect to be felt. This principle of end focus also effectively applies to single tone units where the writer proceeds from information assumed to be shared to information that is assumed to be news to the reader. For example a sentence like "she stole *everything*" may follow general information that something was stolen.

Since the sounds in written prose derive from the natural sounds of every day communication, written prose has an implicit, non-verbalized intonation which is indicated by punctuation marks.

(c) Point of View

The term *point of view* refers to the perspective or vantage point from which a story is told. In prose fiction, there is always a fictive presence that the writer employs to tell the story. A story may be told from three main vantage points:

(i) I narrator/First person point of view

In some prose fiction, the narrator is a participant in the actions of the story and gives himself the identity *I*. Whereas it is common for readers to mistake this narrator for the writer, this is not always the case except in the autobiographical novels. What the writer does is to withdraw from the text and assign the duty of story telling to a

character in the work going by the appellation *I*. Since it is the I narrating the story while at the same time partaking in the experiences of the work, then he becomes a first person narrator. George Lamming's *In The Castle of My Skin* is told through such a point of view.

The advantage of the first person narration is that it leads to a feeling of intimacy between the narrator and the reader to the extent that the reader becomes prejudiced in favour of this narrative character. The reader tends to empathize and believes in what this character says. It is even possible to convert the reader into holding the views of the narrator even when such views contradict the reader's own stand in real life.

(ii) Omniscient narrator/Third person narrator

This is the most common angle of vision employed in prose fiction. As the word omniscient suggests, this narrator is an all-knowing observer. He knows everything about the past, present and future. He is knowledgeable about every place and certainly has the capability to follow the characters everywhere. Also, the omniscient character knows every character deeply: how a character feels, even what he thinks. This is the point of view employed in most of Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's novels.

(iii) Limited omniscient point of view

Sometimes, a prose fiction writer may decide to narrate the story in the third person but through one of the characters. The information given by this narrator depends and is in fact restricted to what this character experiences, feels, sees, hears or thinks. It is because such a narrative is restricted or limited to the perceptions of the narrating character that this point of view is labeled *limited omniscient*.

A good example of the limited omniscient point of view is in Mariama Ba's novel *So Long a Letter* where the entire story is told from the point of view of what the narrators (Ramatoulaye and Aissatou) feel, observe or experience. We never get a

chance to listen to what Ramatoulaye's husband Modou Fall and Aissatou's ex-husband Mawdo have to say about the accusations leveled against them.

Note

Although we have discussed three main angles of vision, it should be noted that it is not always the case that a writer will use one form of narration throughout a text. A writer may choose to use more than one type within a single work. For example, although the bulk of Ngugi's *A Grain of Wheat* is narrated in the third person, there are cases where we get to view things from the perspective of Mugo. Chinua Achebe's novel *Anthills of the Savannah* and Alice Walker's *Possessing the Secrets of Joy* are also complex amalgams of several limited omniscient perspectives. That is, the stories in the two novels are told from the perspectives of not one but several characters.

point of view used in any novel you have read.

(d) "An Illusion of Reality"/Verisimilitude

Literary critics concur that unlike the genres of literature which emphasize on economy of words such as poetry, proverbs and riddles, prose fiction aims at convincing or persuading through *faithfulness to truth*. In literary terms, this truthful treatment of material is called *realism* or *verisimilitude*. *Realism* is considered to be the most important distinguishing feature of prose. The prose writer has boundless space to creatively imitate aspects of social reality as accurately as possible. He imitates the thoughts, actions, manners and the talk of real people. In this generic framework, every character, location and incident are elaborated in such a way as to

be representative to some extent of an aspect of human experience. The reader is therefore drawn into reading through a work a prose in order to see what happened to people like him or her. Certainly, pictures of everyday life and experience catch the reader's interest quite easily. Such pictures also easily arouse the reader's emotions of empathy or pity. Indeed, in serious prose fiction, the central issues of human life tend to be moral. The prose writer selects an aspect of human conduct which he endeavours to present as accurately as it affects people in real situations. A prose writer may explore historical issues such as slavery, colonialism, war or epidemics like Ebola, HIV Aids and the recent phenomenon of SARS (severe acute respiratory syndrome) in order to address moral concerns such as racism, religious fundamentalism, death of the innocent, promiscuity, health and sanitation. Characterization is therefore central to creating an illusion of reality. Apart from content and characterization, there are other interlinking strategies that a prose writer employs to create realism.

These include: plot, conflict, dialogue and description. Let us now look at these devices of *verisimilitude*:

(i) Chronology of events

In totality, prose fiction tends towards a unified picture of *real things* – characters, places, and occurrences. Every portion of a prose work be it a sentence, paragraph or chapter, is related and naturally springs from another sentence, paragraph and chapter. What this means is that there is *natural* or logical movement of events - chronological build-up of ideas. A leads to B, B happens as a result of A. B incites what we may call C. C is therefore not an orphaned idea from the moon. Its source is well known and can be traced to B. This rational sequencing is what we call *plot* in literary terms. It means that one event causes or leads to another realistically. An event will only make sense if we know its cause. In ordinary life, man and woman create a child/person. The person has to eat and breathe to survive. The person falls sick or gets old and stops breathing and therefore dies. One thing logically leads to another. In literature too things happen *propter hoc* (because of) and not *post hoc* (mechanically one after another). Causality is the essence of plot and it is indeed what creates a semblance of reality. A rational movement creates credibility which

consequently influences a reader's ability to make sense out of a story. At the end of the prose work, one thing has led to another, questions have been asked and answered and the reader is able to understand why things are the way they are. However, this does not mean that a writer always resolves all mysteries by the time the story ends. A writer may choose to end his story at a point where we expect certain things to happen. For example Alex La Guma's novel *In the fog of the season's end* concludes with some young African men being taken for military training in the north. Our hope and positive prediction is that they will come back armed with military skills and that they will eventually crush the apartheid regime. Our silent wish as readers is that such a future could be determined from the novel itself rather than through sheer supposition.

(ii) Conflict

The chronology of events in a literary work involves people whose actions inter-relate to constitute a unified whole. **Conflict** is a crucial issue in the inter-relations.

The term conflict in literature implies a struggle of a character against someone or something. There must be a rationale or convincing motivation for the struggle. Conflict could emanate from factors propelled and indeed only justified by psychological traits of a character or external events. Essentially, all fiction grows from some form of struggle involving people. Conflict entails such struggles between opposing forces. The struggle may originate from:

- (1) forces within the individual as is the case in many psychological novels. In Richard Wright's *Native Son*, Bigger Thomas is such a person.
- (2) the protagonist being in conflict with another person. In Dostoevsky's *Brother's Karamazov*, Fyodor Pavlovich struggles with his sons, legitimate and illegitimate. In Ngugi's *A Grain of Wheat*, Gikonyo and Karanja are embroiled in many conflicts.

- (3) The individual struggling against forces of nature. In Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea*, the child Antoinette is ill at ease with her whiteness. In Dickens' *Hard Times*, Gradgrind tries to play God by trying to create a scientifically factual world devoid of any speck of fancy and art.
- (4) A person struggling against society as a force. For example, in his intransigence, Okonkwo in Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* tries to stop the society from embracing any attributes from the West. But can an individual stop a whole society? He fails and in his frustrations, he commits suicide.

(iii) Dialogue

In order to create a semblance of reality through credible, natural characters, a writer makes his characters speak in a manner consistent with their age, education, profession, social status and other factors. A conversation between two or more people presents an interplay of ideas. Since two people of exactly the same background (social, educational, religious etc.) habits and personal qualities rarely meet, in prose writing, a writer carefully selects the language he ascribes to either character in order to highlight these differences. Some of the linguistic strategies that a writer may use to differentiate characters are as follows:

(1) Dialect

A dialect is a variety of the same language which is determined by geographical differences. For example among English speakers there are several dialects such as the American and British dialects. Vocabulary is a good dialect marker. For instance where a British talks of *lavatory*, and American would refer to the same as a *rest room*. Other examples include: *Cookies* (American) – *Biscuits* (British) and *Truck* (American) – *Lorry* (British).

In Kiswahili we also have several dialects which novelists like Said Ahmed Mohammed exploit fruitfully to mark out their characters. Whereas most of the characters in Mohammed's novels speak in the standard Kiunguja dialect, he also gives some characters other kiswahili dialects.

Dialects can also be determined by social status. It is argued that the British royal family speaks a more polished version of the English language, what we commonly refer to as the Queen's English.

Dialect is indeed a very effective tool for creating realistic characters.

(2) Idiolect

Whereas dialect is the variety of language with many speakers, *idiolect* is the individual's *dialect*. Every human being has his own special way of communicating that marks him off as an individual. He prefers using particular words or phrases and speaks in a particular manner. In totality, idiolect alludes to the unique, individual speech habits. These speech habits may entail speech defects such as stammering or lisping. For example, for purposes of realism, Charles Dickens artfully makes one character in *Hard Times* (Sleary) to lisp in his talk. This also adds to creation of humour in the novel. A good writer carefully and consistently selects the language he gives each character so that it becomes very easy to identify the characters from their speech habits.

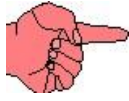
(3) Non-fluent Speech

Apart from dialect and idiolect, writers also try to imitate the features of impromptu speeches in the dialogue of their characters.

In written speeches, people have time to plan their utterances - to choose the words and structures to use. Although in ordinary speech there is also some quick mental planning depending on the direction of a talk, our planning often falls behind delivery. Many a times we find ourselves pausing or filling such pauses with stopgap sounds like *eeh*, *er erm*, *mmm*. Undeniably, ordinary everyday communication also tends to be loose. Speakers may use words and initial signals like “you know” and “well” which add nothing to the idea being communicated. Also, ordinary speech is often characterized by Syntactic (word-order) mistakes. An example is one recently said by a member of parliament referring to a retired president as: “his excellency the president, the former”. There is inconsistent sequence of words here and repetition of definite noun “the”. A common mistake is that of linking all clauses in a sentence by “and”. For example: *when I heard the loud noise in my sleep, I woke up and drew the curtains and looked outside to see what was amiss*. Other features of ordinary speech include: false starts, interruptions, sudden change of topic, interaction signals such as “isn’t it?”, cliché expressions and colloquial language. Indeed it would not be realistic for a writer to make a character speak impeccably, consistently, in ordinary speech.

Apart from sheer representation of a conversation, the non- fluency features of ordinary speech can have a communicative significance. For example, frequent hesitations may suggest either nervousness or simply cautious choice of words on the part of the speaker.

Note



(i) Since ordinary speech may be ill organized to the point of disturbing and irritating a reader, a literary writer does not give a photocopy representation of such speech. Unless frequent, some features of non-fluency are rarely noticed by the hearer. A writer may therefore omit such features from the dialogue of his characters without causing any damage to the *illusion of reality* created.

(ii) Depiction of these aspects of ordinary speech is not limited to prose. It is more marked in drama, which, as you know, survives on representation of ordinary conversation.

example Francis in Michael Anthony's novel *The Year in San Fernando* is said to be exactly twelve years old. A writer may even describe a character's height, dental formula, temperament, habits, preferences and every other small detail.

(iv) Description rose writers have the space to paint a real picture using words. The general trend of prose fiction is to thematize from a universal perspective while narrowing on specific themes. This narrowing down of universal ideas, people, and events is what leads to an elaboration of detail. This is because it is not humanly possible to deal with so much at one given time. The author therefore concentrates more on a few characters, incidents and ideas. He treats these aspects to detail. The writer mentions the size, shape, colour, texture of a thing and even speed of

movement of an action. The writer may tell you the exact age of a character. For

Such detailed explanation or portrayal is what we call *description*.

Let us look at the first paragraph of Charles Dickens' *Bleak House*:

LONDON. Michaelmas Term lately over, and the Lord Chancellor sitting in Lincoln's Inn Hall. Implacable November weather. As much mud in the streets, as the waters had but newly retired from the face of the earth, and it would not be wonderful to meet a megalosaurus, forty feet long or so, waddling like an elephantine lizard up Holborn Hill. Smoke lowering down from chimney-pots, making a soft black

drizzle, with flakes of soot in it as big as full-grown snow-flakes – gone into mourning, one might imagine, for the death of the sun. Dogs, undistinguishable in mire. Horses, scarcely better; splashed to their very blinkers. Foot passengers, jostling one another's umbrellas, in a general infection of ill-temper, and losing their foot-hold at street-corners, where tens of thousands of other foot passengers have been slipping and sliding since the day broke (if this day ever broke), adding new deposits to the crust upon crust of mud, sticking at those points tenaciously to the pavement, and accumulating at compound interest. (p.1)

In this paragraph, Dickens begins by being specific about his subject in a one-worded ungrammatical sentence: LONDON. Then he goes ahead to describe the city of London. What we get is not a likeable picture: muddy streets, smoky, abounding with grubby dogs and horses whose colour cannot be determined and congested streets where irate pedestrians jostle. This is not a pleasant picture.

Coming at the very beginning of the novel, we as readers are unable to be endeared to this anarchic city right from the start. Through detailed description, we have been prejudiced against London. Therefore, apart from a realistic effect, description has the power to influence the reader in many ways. Description may sway a reader into liking, hating or pitying.

One common device employed in description in the endeavour to paint a portrait of a real life situation is through figures of speech, mostly, the metaphor and simile. The inter-associative meanings of the metaphor and simile make meaning more vivid. Note the impact of such comparisons in Dickens' passage above.

The smoke emitted from chimneys makes flakes of soot which are as big as "full grown snow flake". This simile is combined with a personification and metaphor "mourning ... for the death of the sun" to give an impression of an irredeemable situation. Pedestrians have been metaphorically named "foot passengers" to emphasize how much they depend on their legs for movement. One gets the feeling that owing to their economic status, such people are doomed to walk.

Such a feeling makes us empathize with this poor majority.

The detailed individualization of characters, things and ideas, through description, gives the reader a sense of verisimilitude: being in the presence of actual people, things locations and events. When a reader gets a feeling of familiarity with fictional people, places, actions and ideas being explored, he is brought closer to the experiences of the novel. He ceases to be just a reader. He becomes an active participant or observer.

Note

Other forms of art such as sculpturing and film are purely sensory in the sense that one sees or listens to the details then “feels”. However, while sensory/sense devices such as figures of speech, illustrations and even pictures may be employed in literature to provide more detail, description through language is limited to literature.

6.4 Summary

In this lecture we have looked at the general characteristics of prose: grammatical, graphological and phonological features, realism and point of view. Under realism, we have discussed four main strategies of creating an illusion of reality: chronology, conflict, dialogue and description. Under dialogue, several aspects of ordinary speech have been looked at. We have noted that sound features, which are important in poetry, can also be fruitfully employed in prose.

6.5 Activity



Referring to Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's *A Grain of Wheat* or Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*, show how the elements of realism discussed in this lesson are manifested.

LESSON SEVEN

TYPES OF PROSE: The Short story and the Novel

7.0 Introduction

Having examined the general characteristics of prose in our last lecture, in this seventh lecture and the next one, I will center on particular prose forms. I will focus more on features that distinguish one prose form from another. In this seventh lecture I will narrow down on fictional prose: the short story and the novel.

7.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Identify features of a short story
2. Define the word “novel” in specific terms
3. Describe aspects of a novel.

7.2 Prose Forms

Literary prose forms are numerous. They include: the novel, short story, biography, autobiography, essay, memoirs, diaries and journals. Some oriental countries such as Japan have even more complicated prose forms such as books of random thoughts and travel accounts. Of all these prose types, the most common and universal are the novel and short story. Although the essay, biography and autobiography also exist in many societies, they have received paltry critical attention. Critics have been more interested in absolute creativity

thus the tendency to center more on the novel and short story, which grow from sheer fiction. However, presently literary critics are beginning to acknowledge that there is certainly great imagination also employed in the factual prose forms such as the autobiography.

7.3 The Short Story

Drawing its genesis from the folk narratives of the pre-literate man, the *short story* has a history as old as man himself. Egyptians have records of short stories dating as far back as 4000 B.C. In the Old Testament of the Bible, we also encounter many stories narrated hundreds of years before Jesus Christ was born. In the New Testament, Christ himself tells many short stories popularly known as *parables*. However, the short story as we know it today as a fictional prose form was consciously conceived in the West in the middle of the nineteenth century following the prescriptions of Edgar Allan Poe.

Despite being more than one and a half centuries old, the short story remains one of the most elusive literary genres in that it can only be described but cannot be defined. It is difficult to define a short story because, in terms of length, it cannot be measured. A short story can be short, medium or long. Some critics have even suggested that some “short” stories could even be longer than the novel.

Although several critics have attempted to define the short story, no definition has been accepted as perfect. For example Edgar Allan Poe, a key initiator of the short story genre, defines the short story as a prose form that requires half an hour to one

or two hours in its reading. What if the reading takes fifteen minutes or two and a half hours? Does it then cease to be a short story? Time cannot be a good measure to define a prose form.

Holman (1972) defines the short story as a fictional narrative in prose constituting of between five hundred to fifteen thousand words. Although Holman goes on to describe salient features of the short story form, sheer number of words cannot be a reliable distinguishing factor. What if the number of words are less, say four hundred?

Then there are those who define the short story as prose narrative that can be read at a *sitting*. Now, how does one define a *sitting*? How long is a *sitting*? *Sitting* here can be vague or relative. It is humanly possible to read continuously for four hours or more. So when does such a *sitting* cease to be a *sitting*? It is obvious that such a definition cannot hold.

Unable to come up with a crisp and simple definition of the short story form, literary scholars have come up with such amorphous terms as “Short-short story”, and “long-short story”.

A practical definition of the short story must encompass the key distinguishing features that set the short story off from other fictional prose. We will now examine the distinctive characteristics of the short story.

(1) Plot

Just like the longer prose forms, the short story has a plot with a beginning, middle and end. However, the plot in a short story is generally simple. Whereas the novel could have more than one plot, the short story usually has a single plot. This is because the short story has space enough only to allow concentration on a single effect. The totality of this effect is the central aim to which every detail in the story is supposed to subordinate. For example the totality of effect of Grace Ogot's story

“Tekayo” in *Encounters From Africa* is unraveling the mystery of the strange meet. This mystery brings to the fore the main theme of greed on the part of Tekayo. His hysterical cravings for the kind of meat he stole from the eagle make him even endanger his life in a reckless search of this delicacy in the forest. When he cannot get this unidentified meat from the beasts of wild life,

Tekayo’s unbridled gluttony eventually leads him into killing his own grandchildren. The single effect of Sam Kahiga’s “The Last Breath” in the same anthology is with regard to the theme of love. The story revolves around a young man who is also the narrator, his girl friend/fiancée and his father. The narrator father’s is opposed to his son’s relationship with a blind girl by the name Eva. As a caring and loving father, he can only imagine his son having an unhappy married life because of Eva’s blindness. However, the narrator is adamant that this is the girl he loves. This obstinacy creates tension between father and son. Being, a lung-cancer patient, the narrator’s father’s condition is worsened by the tension between him and his son. It is love again that resolves the tension but in a rather ironical and strange manner. The dying father still loves his son despite the fact that it is the latter’s stubbornness and disobedience that had aggravated his health. On his deathbed, the father donates his cornea to his son’s fiancée to enable Eva see again.

(2) Narrative form

The plot of a short story gives information more readily. The writer has little room to digress or engage in elaborate description. See how we are told so much in just one paragraph in the opening paragraph of Amos Tutuola’s short story “Ajaiyi and the witch doctor” in *Encounters from Africa*:

Several years ago there was an old man who lived in a village. He was a farmer and he had one son named Ajaiyi. This man was so poor that all of his friends and neighbours believed that he was really created in poverty by his creator. After several years’ hard work this poor old man became too old and weary to work in his farm. But Ajaiyi, his only son, took over from him. He was working hard in his old father’s farm and by that he was getting sufficient food to feed his father and himself.

Ajaiyi worked as hard as he could until he became thirty years old but yet, he and his father's poverty became worse than ever. (p.24)

Note how details are severely pared down in this paragraph. Being the opening paragraph, one would expect to be furnished with all information about this Old man. For example does he have a name? Who is the mother of his son Ajaiyi? What is the name of the village where the old man lived? What exactly is the source of his poverty? Such details are left out because they are not very important here. The writer only focuses on the nitty-gritty. In fact at the end of the few opening sentences we have learnt about things that happened in "several years".

(3) Characters

Whereas the longer prose fiction may have tens of characters, the short story has a very limited number of characters. Of these few characters, most short stories concentrate more on a single character. For example in Gaelle Sabbott-Mogwe's story "Smile of Fortune" in *Encounters From Africa*, the author concentrates on Khumo. In Ezekiel Mphahlele's "Man Must Live" in the same anthology, Khalima Zungu is the only *developed* (that is, compared to other characters in the same story) character.

A short story has little space for lengthy character evolution. Therefore the characters may appear lopsided in the sense that we only get to know one side of them. There is no room to present all facets of the characters. The writer only concentrates on the most salient features; central features that can help the reader understand the main concerns of the story. Also, the character in a short story has no room to develop convincingly. While in a novel a character may be born, baptized, marry and die, a short story has little room for such character development. For example in Achebe's worldly acclaimed novel *Things Fall Apart*, the author meticulously furnishes the reader with details appertaining to Okonkwo's humble beginnings and the social institutions that harp on manliness

and achievement, in order to enable the reader understand why Okonkwo is the way he is – fearful of failure, impatient with the weak and unsuccessful and violent in nature. We

are told that he had a good-for-nothing father who was an embarrassment to his society. Okonkwo's driving force in life springs from this. He works hard in order to obliterate the image of his father and gain respect for himself and his family. There is a very convincing character presentation in this novel which is made possible by the very length of the novel. A short story has little room for such character-development.

(4) Setting

Whereas the longer prose form may focus on many locations, a short story tends to limit itself to one main location. For example Tutuola's "Ajaiyi and the witch doctor" in *Encounters from Africa* is set in a village farm. Grace Ogot's "Tekayo" is also set in a traditional Luo society. Bessie Head's "The Prisoner who wore glasses" is set in a jail situation in a racially prejudiced South African nation. Majority if not all the prisoners in this dungeon are non-white political prisoners. Even though the actions in the story shift from various quarters of the prison, the writer mainly concentrates on the actions of one prisoner, Brille and a prisoner warder, Hannetjie. The setting of Dongala's "The Man" is plainly an African country that is governed by a crude and callous tyrant. The 'man' who eventually single-handedly assassinates the despot is therefore as his name suggests, not a particular but a representative of the general citizenry. The author does not mention specific place in this story to imply that there is social discontent all over the country and a yearning for change. Therefore, any person from any part of the country could have done what 'the man' did. The country is also not named. This implies that it could be any nation in Africa where such autocratic regimes existed. It will be remembered that less than two decades ago Africa was proliferated with ruthless dictators. These include: Idi Amin Dada of

Uganda, Bokassa and Mobutu Seseseko of Central Africa and many military rulers in several West African countries. The choice of an unnamed locality and persons is therefore very significant in this story. It makes this story a symbolic one therefore making it possible for the reader to relate the events of this story to what happens (or happened) in any African country. The story applies across the board in terms of examining and lashing at totalitarian governments in the world. Dongala's argument is that such dictators, who impose themselves and their eccentricities on their people

and yet continue deceiving themselves that that they are the best thing that happened to their nations, cannot be safe as long as the common man still possesses the natural urge to be free. So, it is only a question of time in cahoots with a general of a spirit of oneness before such despots are obliterated.

(5) Time

In terms of time, most short stories deal with moments in time. Hence a short story may take a day, a night, a week, a month or couple of months. Most novels focus on experiences spanning several months or years. The events in Tayeb Salih's story "A Handful of Dates" (*Encounters from Africa*) take just a couple of hours. In spite of this, the author employs a few flashbacks to tell us of some aspects of the past that are crucial to understanding the brief present. Chinua Achebe's "The Voter" in the same anthology specifically focuses on an election time in Nigeria. Achebe puts his spotlight on an election period in order to draw attention to the Nigerian political structure. Although the time reflected is not a long one, we learn a lot about a political system riddled with corruption. Bribery is the order of the day. Politicians have no scruples literally buying votes from the electorate. The agents of the candidates unabashedly bargain and haggle about the price of a vote. Blackmail is rampant. The electorate may be blackmailed into voting for candidates they do not prefer. One such victim of blackmail is Rufus Okeke who is literally coerced into voting for Maduka instead of Marcus. We also learn that politics is seen as an open sesame to riches. The empty promises and political intrigues that characterize the election period are therefore a reflection of the politicians' selfishness and overwhelming greed. All they care about is satiating their egos by gaining abundant material wealth quickly. By just centring on a period, Achebe gives us a general outlook of the many problems bedeviling his country.

(6) Intensity/Compactness

Because short stories are *short* (in the sense that they have limited room for exposition, evolution of characters and many themes), a writer has a rigid framework

within which to say what he has to say and say it effectively. It is because of this that short stories tend to be compact in their nature, faster in their pace and intense in capturing a moment or aspect of an experience. The writer carefully sifts through all material at his disposal and only employs those capable of passing his message expeditiously but also powerfully.

7.4 The Novel

A *novel* is an extended fictional prose narrative. Although some literary scholars talk of limits in terms of words such as a minimum of fifty thousand words, again, such definitions can be problematic.

For a long time, the word *novel* and *romance* were taken to mean the same thing.

Literary critics have now been able to draw a clear line. Unlike the romance which imaginatively focused on the supernatural, improbable things and fabulous people, the novel creatively centers on probable things, real people and events.

Indeed, this is the essence of a novel – reflecting nature in a probable manner so as to persuade the reader to believe in the reality of what he is reading. It is in this

regard that Anna Laetitia Barbauld (1840) in “On the Origin and Progress of Novel-writing” says: “A good novel is an epic in prose, with more of character and less (indeed in modern novels nothing) of the supernatural machinery”.

The novelist has all the space to create scenes of familiar life in an elegant and interesting manner in order to persuade his readers. It may not be possible to effectively imitate the ordinary train of human events in a few pages. Owing to the details that have to be included in order to persuade readers, the length of a novel is determined by the nature of persuasion aimed at. Little wonder we are unlikely to find novels of less than ninety pages. Such ‘novels’ will tend to be hurried or have many components significantly pared down. They will therefore tend to behave like *novellas*. If the nature of the novel automatically determines its minimum length, we cannot determine the extent to which a writer can endeavour to portray a true picture

of his fictional world. It is because of this that we have novels with as many as two thousand pages. Leo Tolstoy's *War and Peace* is one of the longest novels ever written. Locally the longest novel is *The Broken Drum* by David Maillu which has more than one thousand pages.

Now let us look at some of the strategies a novelist employs in order to present a realistic picture.

(1) The Story and Plot

The backbone of all narrative and dramatic literary genres is the *story*. A short story, novella, novel and play cannot exist without a *story*. Some series of happenings or character development must have presented itself to a writer's imagination in a powerful manner that the writer thought it viable to tell it to others.

A *story* refers to the narrative of events in their time sequence. The *story* has the merit of making the audience want to know what happened next. Sometimes the terms story and plot are mistaken to mean the same thing. Whereas the terms are related, they are not essentially synonymous. A story is merely an ingredient of plot (refer to our earlier elaborate definition of the term plot). Whereas the story concentrates purely on time sequence of action, the plot focuses on causality – how one action instigates or gives rise to another. Further, a plot organizes the actions in a mode suggested by Aristotle: giving the story a structure consisting of a beginning, middle and end.

(2) Characterization

In literature, a character refers to a person in a story. This person is an imaginary creation and has no existence outside the literary work. He is simply a realistic vehicle for the enumeration of a literary writer's sensibilities. The creation of such life-like fictive persons is what we call *characterization* in literary terms.

If the novel cannot survive without a story, then a story cannot survive without a sequence of actions. It also follows logically that there cannot be such actions without characters even if such characters are animals or insects.

Unlike drama where characterization depends solely on characters' action and dialogue (what characters do and say), the presentation of characters in prose can be done in three ways:

(a) Exposition

The principal fictional method of character presentation is through direct *exposition*. A writer explicitly explains the nature of character in continuous prose. Such explanation may include description, illustration, comparison and contrast. The writer tells us a character's name, age and describes her physical appearance. He also tells us of her social status, her dressing mode, the company of people she prefers and many other traits. We judge the character through such explanations. To explain the root of Kihika's revolutionary nature, Ngugi uses such exposition in the novel *A Grain of Wheat*:

Kihika's interest in politics began when he was a small boy and sat under the feet of Warui listening to stories of how the land was taken from the black people. That was before the second world war, that is, before Africans were conscripted to fight with Britain against Hitler in a war that was never their own. Warui needed only a listener; he recounted the deeds of Waiyaki and other warriors, who, by 1900 had been killed in the struggle to drive out the white man from the land; of young Harry and the fate that befell the 1923 procession; of Muthirigu and the mission schools that forbade circumcision in order to eat, like insects, both the roots and stem of the Gikuyu society. Unknown to those around him, Kihika's heart hardened towards 'these people', long before he had even encountered a white face. Soldiers came back from the war and told stories of what they had seen in Burma, Egypt, Palestine and India; wasn't Mahatma Gandhi, the saint, leading the Indian people against British rule? Kihika fed on these stories: his imagination and daily observation told him the rest; from early on, he had

visions of himself, a saint, leading the Gikuyu to freedom and power. (p.72/73)

From this expository paragraph, we are able to garner a number of factors that have instigated the spirit of struggle in Kihika. Like other heroes of freedom, Kihika entertains a messianic vision of himself. Like Jesus Christ, Kihika has seen the suffering of Kenyans and therefore aspires to lead his people from a political Egypt into a political Canaan. Through such explanations in this novel, we are able to understand Kihika's courage, assertiveness and defiance. His bravery is seen in his readiness to sacrifice his life in order to realize his vision of an independent Kenya.

Explicit presentation in prose in itself is not enough. In fact, lengthy, unequivocal, same-styled presentations may fatigue the reader. Good writers vary their narrative modes in order to maintain the reader's interest. Readers also want to see the characters act on their own just like in normal life. Exposition in prose is therefore frequently blended with and supported by *action*.

Now let us look at *action*.

(b) Action

Borrowing from the dramatic method, a prose writer may make his characters act and talk. In such a presentation, the author does not make any comments which may prejudice how we (the readers) evaluate the characters. Rather, the writer lets the reader judge the persons in the story from what they do and say.

For example, we can easily judge Martin in Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye's *Coming to Birth* as an impatient person and a chauvinist from the way he molests his wife Paulina for getting lost in the city even though she is very new to the city:

The key was in the padlock. As the door opened he gave her a hard push over towards the bed so that she fell to the floor, grazing her knees and knocking her forehead on the wooden frame.

'Slut! Whore! Is that what you came to Nairobi for?' 'But they would not let me ...'

‘Too busy about the city, are you, to sit at the gate like anyone else waiting for me to come? If you had bothered to find the way you would have found the house locked, wouldn’t you, wouldn’t you? And spent the rest of the day wandering about Pumwani making enquiries as you call it – wouldn’t you, wouldn’t you?’

His hand slapped across her cheek and again across her shoulders. ‘Want to come and live in Nairobi as somebody’s wife, do you – do you?’

His fist was pummeling into the small of her back and he began pulling at the bed as though to overturn it on top of her. ‘Two nights. Where did you spend those two nights?’ ‘With Susanna and her husband in a place called Makongeni – I’ll take you there ...’

‘And that is how the white woman came to bring you?’ ‘No, no. The first night Susanna found me. She is a saved sister. I can take you to the church. You will see. And the second ...’

‘The second day you couldn’t get any of those great friends of yours to come to Shah & Sons Printers, Reatta Road, to find me? You couldn’t get anyone to telephone? You cant bloody well remember five numbers?’ He kicked her buttocks.

‘Martin, you never told me. The name, the number, you never told me at all Oh-oh. And there is still bleeding.’ ‘Bleeding there may be. Can’t even keep a baby for me.

Can’t even be sure it was mine, can I? – Whore! – Bitch ... She screamed as he came flailing towards her... (p.21/22)

The actions and words of Martin here vividly give a picture of a bigoted man. He is a man who has virtually no regard for women. Martin is a man who views a woman as a simple mindless toy – who if not chaperoned and guarded may easily stray into another man’s bed. On the other hand we see Paulina as an obedient and respectful woman. She is also docile and obsequious – she is molested but can only scream and hope that Martin will not send her packing back to her parents. Such a lucid and lurid portrait of the qualities of man and wife could not have been so dramatically powerful had it simply been narrated.

(c) Interior Characterization

An author may also portray a character from the inner self. Here, the writer does not comment on the person's traits but allows the reader to reach his own verdict as to how internal attributes of the person impact on the external or vice-versa. Devices that a prose writer employs in order to explore the inner self of a

character include: stream of consciousness, interior/internal monologue and monologue (ordinary). Let us now explain these terms

Internal Monologue

In *internal monologue* a writer articulates the internal thoughts and emotional experiences of a character. A reader gets the feeling of 'overhearing' the sensations and thoughts flowing through a character's mind; sensations and thoughts which the character never makes verbal. Such mental 'talks' are usually disjointed and unorganized. A good prose writer represents them in the same manner in order to be realistic to the unorganized flow of the mind.

Often, *interior monologue* is used as an alternative term for *stream of consciousness*. Although the two terms are related, *stream of consciousness* is the wider umbrella term that includes internal monologue. Stream of consciousness alludes to the total spectrum of awareness that derives from mental and emotional processes. It includes: introspection (thoughts), retrospection (memories and reflections), dreams, associations and monologue.

Monologue

A *monologue* presents a conversation of one speaker, that is, a character talking to himself. In ordinary life, a monologue is more often than not a product of a mind that is psychologically agitated, ill

at ease or harassed. We often see normal people walking while talking to themselves because of their social or financial woes. By and large, such people are not even conscious

that they are speaking to themselves. Likewise, in literature a character brings out his hidden feelings through monologue. A monologue therefore enables the reader to know what he may not have known.

In *A Grain of Wheat*, Ngugi wa Thiong'o uses internal monologue and ordinary monologue and other stream of consciousness techniques to explore and clarify the mystery and dilemma surrounding many of the characters in the novel. An introvert like Mugo, who talks little, can only be understood from the psychological perspective. Hence, Ngugi uses appropriate stream of consciousness skills to enter Mugo's heart and mind and reveal to us Mugo's psychological conflicts.

Here is a practical example from the novel:

As soon as Gikonyo had gone, Mugo rushed to the door, Flung it open and cried out: come back. He waited for an Answer, and getting no response went back and sat down to think. His mind lightly hopped from one episode to another. Gikonyo had wanted him to say something. He felt he should have said something. Twice he had moistened his lips with spittle and cleared his throat ready to speak. But his mouth was dry; thoughts and words refused to form. What could he have told him? Gikonyo's

outburst against Karanja's betrayal and his unforgiving anger at Mumbi had made Mugo recoil within. Every time Gikonyo talked about Mumbi and Karanja, Mugo felt sharp irritation as if acid was eating away at an ulcer in his stomach. He now shivered at the recollection. He became restless. He stood up and walked about the room. Suppose I had told him ... Suppose I had suddenly told him...

Everything would have been all over... all over... the knowledge ... the burden ... fears... and hopes ... I could have told him ... and maybe ... maybe ... Or is that why he told me his own story? At this thought he abruptly stopped pacing and leaned against the bed. A man does not go to a

stranger and tear his heart open ... I see everything ...
everything ...he pretended not to look at me ...yet kept
stealing eyes at me ... see if I was frightened ... see ... if
... No ... (p.107)

The foregoing offers the reader a chance to learn more about Mugo. Right from the outset, we can tell that Mugo is a guilt-ridden person who is increasingly isolated from his fellow men. Mugo's sense of guilt frustrates his attempts to communicate freely with those around him. Such frustrations are ventilated through monologue (external and internal). Indeed, Mugo also tries to rationalize his secret deeds through such monologues. Note the pauses in the stream of thought. Such pauses serve to heighten what is going on in Mugo's guilt-ridden, discomposed psyche.

7.5 Types of Characters

In *Aspects of the novel*. E.M. Forster asserts that there are only two types of characters: *round* and *flat* characters.

Round Characters

The normal human being has his strengths and weaknesses, likes and dislikes. The ordinary person grows, is flexible and changes with time and according to circumstances. The foregoing shows that a real person is complex. The term *round characters* in literature refers to such complex persons who exhibit convincing life-like congeries of individual features. A good literary writer is expected to employ such three-dimensional major characters. Three-dimensional characters are: full (fully developed), complex (deep - full of meaning) and Rich (multi-faceted and exhibiting many personality traits).

Paulina and Martin in Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye's *Coming to Birth* are good examples of round characters. We see both Paulina and Martin growing physically and psychologically. Paulina develops from a naïve, ignorant village girl to a confident urban woman. And this development is not

haphazard but logical and gradual. Exposure to urban life, traumatic marriage experiences and infectious valuable associates are the main factors that influence the growth of Paulina's character.

Flat characters

Flat characters are closed characters. The writer concentrates too much on a single trait at the expense of other traits. The final product is a rendering of a character that is incredible: inflexible, shallow and one-sided. Such one-sided characters usually come out more as caricatures than as people. In real life, concrete external things that happen to us have the effect of occasioning internal responses and changes. A flat character in literature is minimally modified or not modified at all by such external happenings.

Examples of flat characters abound in Alex La Guma's novella *A Walk in the Night* and Mulk Raj Anand's novel *Coolie*. In La Guma's novella we are presented with a gallery of whites and non-whites who wallow in immense hatred for each other. All the whites are presented as animal-like heartless creatures. The author only harps on the negative aspects of these symbols of apartheid. And he does it to appalling levels. We never at all get to see the other side of these white people. They come out as cartoon strips and not real people. In *Coolie*, Anand exaggerates the wickedness of his vile characters such as Bibiji, Ganpat and Jimmy Thomas. In fact, these characters have no speck of virtue in them. Such characters appear unbelievable.

However, what we have said does not mean that *flat* or *simple* characters have no place in literature. On the contrary, flat characters have the advantage of being *easy to recognize and remember*. Most of the characters in Peter Abrahams novel *Mine Boy* are closed characters and we easily remember them because of their one-sidedness. Even the main character's (Xuma) development is hastened, making him implausible. Nevertheless, the flatness of these characters is not essentially a weakness in the novel. While creating an illusion of reality may only result from delineation of convincing real-life characters, literary writers are not duty-bound to give a photographic representation of real human beings. Literary writers select some features of normal people. They may therefore

decide to develop some of these features while playing down others. Simple characters may be as good as complex ones depending on the goals the writer wishes to achieve through such closed character presentation.

Note

- (i) It is not possible to have all characters, major and minor, presented in a full manner in one piece of literature. Some characters, usually the central actors, are as a rule, fuller than the peripheral actors. It would therefore be a mistake to compare a complex character with a simple one.
- (ii) Because in literature a writer selects traits of people that are essential in the message he wishes to pass, whatever character type one employs must have a function in the total effect intended. Therefore our onus as readers is to find out why the writer decided to present his character the way he did. This responsibility boils down to linking character portrayal to the overall thematic content.

Activity

Basing on your reading of Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's *A Grain of Wheat* or Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*, discuss the range of characters employed.

(3) Setting

The term **setting** refers to the fictional location in which literary action takes place. The commonest location is usually physical/geographical: a room, village, town or country. However, since in many situations the physical goes hand in hand with certain cultural values (moral, social, religious e.t.c.) and history, **setting** encompasses all these. We therefore talk of social and historical setting as well.

A **setting** may also be abstract or mental; that is, the actions of a literary work are presented as happening either in an individual's mind as is the case in most psychological novels, or in some imaginary, even utopian world as is the case in many scientific novels.

While setting in the realistic novel is an important component in the achievement of realism, setting does more than just give a feeling of actions in an ordinary background. An appropriate **setting** contributes to better comprehension of a literary work. The setting of a novel can reveal a lot about a character's personality and theme in general. For example, in *The River Between*, Ngugi uses socio-historical setting to demonstrate the conflicts of character within Muthoni. Despite the fact that her father had embraced the newly arrived

Christian faith and Muthoni was even baptized in the new religion, the traditional spirit still remains strong within her. Muthoni eventually decides to undergo the tribal rite of circumcision in spite of her Christian orientation. This goes on to show the difficulty that Africans underwent in adjusting to two different civilizations. On the wider thematic aspect, Ngugi includes circumstantial information on the natural environment of his setting in order to dramatize the conflicts related to land. Kamenno and Makuyu, essentially not mere ridges but ethnic locations, symbolize this kind of antagonism:

The two ridges lay side by side. One was Kamenno, the other was Makuyu. Between them was a valley. It was called the valley of life. Behind Kamenno and Makuyu were many more valleys and ridges,

lying without any more discernible plan. They were like many sleeping lions which never woke. They just slept, the big deep sleep of their creator ... When you stood in the valley, the two ridges ceased to be sleeping lions united by their common source of life. They became antagonists. You could tell this not by anything tangible but by the way they faced each other, like two rivals ready to come to blows in a life and death struggle for the leadership of this isolated region. (p.1)

The theme of land indeed comes out clearly in this geographic description. The physical location itself hints at potential conflict. The ridges therefore cease to be a mere setting of the novel. Their *antagonistic* topography elevates the ridges to a symbolic level. Hence Kamenno and Makuyu become the very symbol of land struggle not just among the Agikuyus of these two ridges but also the struggle of Africans against the alienation of their land by the white colonizer.

Tied to the setting of the ridges is River Honia. This river has a dual function. It is this river that separates the two ridges. It is also this same river that unites the people of Makuyu and Kamenno. People from both sides draw their water from this river.

Domestic animals, wild animals and plants from both ridges depend on the nourishment from this river for survival. Also, both communities, be it Christians or traditionalists, perform their baptismal ceremonies or initiation rituals at the banks of River Honia. In that regard, the Honia River as a setting is put on a pedestal. This river is imbued with numerous thematic associations. In concert, the two ridges and River Honia provide the novel with an intricate framework that underlies the thematic complexity of the novel.

A novelist will therefore employ appropriate setting in order to achieve various objectives.

Activity

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Look at any novel of your choice and discuss the contribution setting makes to the novel.

(4) Theme

The terms *theme* in literature refers to the ideas explored in the literary text. Typically, we have some ideas dominating over others. The eminent ideas are what we call *primary*, *principle*, *central* or *main* themes. The non-dominant themes are referred to as *secondary* or *minor* themes.

When we discussed the element of realism in literature we said that literary writers aim at reflecting real societies. However, since writers have a vision for their people, they do not simply imitate life. They also reorder that life according to how they wish their world to be. The general subject of literature is therefore life. Yet it is not possible to talk about everything in life. Undoubtedly, writers are inspired into writing by an aspect of life: the murder of a dear friend, a bank robbery, dispossession of land, wife beating, marriage, love and many others. The list of *slices* of life that may provide a writer raw material for a masterpiece are simply inexhaustible. In fact, prose fiction is aimed at providing such slices of life. Whereas a writer may thematize on life as it was (history), a good writer will thematize on a slice of life fathomable and enjoyable to his readers. A literary work on the homo-erectus and dinosaurs may not interest the modern person as much as a story on non-extinct familiar. Likewise, whereas a subject like the repercussions of the industrial revolution in England - which was Dickens' pet subject in his 19th century novels may interest a historical reader or a literary stylistician, it may be dismissed as irrelevant to the general twenty first century reader. To remain relevant, a judicious writer will move with the times and thematize on what is not only familiar but also useful to his readers. In that spirit, locally we have seen writers tackling the burning issues of modern days. One such writer is Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye. Macgoye has demonstrated that kind of movement, writing about colonialism and neo-colonialism to the subject of HIV Aids. Published in 1997,

Chira is such a novel. The novel explores the effect of modern day diseases against the background of rigid traditional perceptions.

Meja Mwangi's *The Last Plague* is also another novel that tackles the subject of Acquired Immuno-deficiency syndrome.

In their latest novels, many Kenyan writers such as Macgoye, Meja Mwangi and Wahome Mutahi address themes related to modern day woes such as: corruption, insecurity, terrorism, poverty and religious hypocrisy. For example, Wahome Mutahi's *Doomsday* effectively deals with the social vice of corruption. Terrorism is presented as an offshoot of corruption and thirst for power. Having witnessed acts of terror locally in (August 1998 Nairobi bomb blast that killed over 250 Kenyans and wounded over four thousand people and the November 2002 Mombasa Paradise Hotel bombing) and internationally (e.g the September 11th 2001 New York World Trade Center bombing in which thousands of

Americans and non-Americans perished) in recent times, such a novel has a powerful effect on a modern reader.

Nevertheless, since the aspects of life that a novelist tackles are 'things' that the reader may already know, what counts eventually and indeed what makes such slices of life *art* is the *freshness* with which they are produced in a literary work. This *fresh* view goes hand in hand with the standpoint from which a writer will illuminate the world for his readers. An author therefore sits down to write because he believes he has some *fresh* ideas about life. If what makes a person an individual is primarily the content of his character more than the physical features, then the intrinsic uniqueness of ideas or themes in a novel will obtain from character development, plot and story, title, setting, dialogue among many other components of style. This means that we cannot have just subject matter in a book without facets of style that are crucial in effectively presenting these themes. In point of fact, a successful investigation of the ideas in a novel essentially entails seeing how these ideas are fashioned.

7.6 Summary

7.7 Activity



Using *A Grain of Wheat* or *Things Fall Apart* or any novel of your choice, answer the following questions:

- (i) What does the title say about the theme(s) of the novel? Is the title appropriate?
- (ii) Do(es) the setting(s) express the theme in any way?
- (iii) What aspect(s) of life is the author interested in?
- (iv) How are the characters presented? What do these characters represent? Does the writer convey any themes through or in their dialogue?
- (v) Did you encounter any symbols? What is the significance of these symbols?
- (vi) What is your personal feeling about the themes you have encountered?

LESSON EIGHT

TYPES OF NOVELS

8.0 Introduction

In our seventh lecture we extensively discussed aspects of the short story and the novel. Now, the novel comes in many varied forms. In this lecture we will describe the various types of the novel.

8.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Identify and describe the various forms of novels available.
2. Classify a novel.

8.2 Episodic Novel

An episode is an occurrence presented as continuous, unbroken action. This means that an episode has cohesion within itself – it has a beginning, middle and end and can therefore make sense on its own. An episodic novel exhibits such independent incidents loosely woven together. That is, the episodes in an episodic novel simply follow each other with no causal relationship. The only common denominator of such incidents is the single character to whom they happen.

A good example of an episodic novel is Mulk Raj Anand's *Coolie*. Let us look at its episodic manifestations.

In five phases, *Coolie* recounts the experiences of Munoo, a hillboy who, at the age of fourteen, is forced to leave his tranquil village in the Kangra Valley so that he may work and be self-independent. The five phases of this novel are loosely attached to each other. The first phase narrates Munoo's idyllic life in the hills in spite of the tribulations engendered by his poverty. The author explains the root cause of Munoo's poverty in a tear-jerking manner. We are told of how a callous landlord dispossessed his father of land and consequently, how the father died a slow death of resentment and frustration. Left a destitute, Munoo's mother's also died soon after. By giving the reader this background, the author wants him to understand where Munoo is coming from – why this child is in the care of his aunt and uncle.

In the second phase, Munoo is in Bilaspur where his uncle has taken him to work for Babu Nathoo Ram, a sub-accountant of the Imperial bank of Bilaspur. In Bilaspur, Munoo is ill treated by Nathoo Ram's ever nagging and quarrelsome wife, Bibiji. Bibiji is shrewish and malicious and has no regard for the likes of Munoo. Munoo is made to work from dawn to dusk, eats stale food (literally starved) and endures all kinds of bestiality. In spite of the over-working, Munoo is only paid a wage of three rupees, which is all taken by his uncle. When Munoo cannot bear it any more, he runs away, hides in a train without really knowing or caring where he will end up next. That brings us to the third phase whereby Munoo has found himself in another town named Daulatpur.

By coincidence, one of the men in the train Munoo boarded, Mr. Prabha Dyal, co-owns a primitive pickle and jam factory in Daulatpur. It is this Prabha who rescues Munoo and treats him like a son. In the meantime, Munoo works at the pickle and jam factory. In Daulatpur, life is smooth to an extent except for Prabha's partner, Ganpat, who, being unkind and villainy, mistreats Munoo and hurls insults at the child's innocent head. Ganpat is also a deceitful person who later swindles the factory, bankrupts it, forcing it to be sold out. With the factory sold, Munoo had to look for means of survival elsewhere. He goes to try his luck at the grain and vegetable markets. It is in these markets that, through Munoo, the author demonstrates the epic magnitude of suffering that the Coolies had to undergo. In the markets, there is ruthless competition between the innumerable, unclothed, famished Coolies, each competing with the others for jobs at awfully miserable remuneration. According to Anand, the Coolies are reduced to the level of animals. With no place to lay their heads at night, these Coolies are even forced to sleep with the bullocks in the square courtyard. Unable to cope with the cut-throat competition, Munoo tries working at the railway station but he is terrified out of his wits by a police man and made to flee for his dear life. In running away, Munoo is rescued by a kind-hearted elephant-driver who enables him to get to Bombay. This brings us to the fourth phase.

Being a bigger city than Daulatpur, we see greater misery in Bombay. Firstly, whereas in Daulatpur it is mainly the Coolies (apart from a few other destitutes) who would be found sleeping in courtyards, in Bombay there is a whole concourse of emaciated pavement dwellers. The street dwellers consist of vagrants, lepers, the sick and the dying. It is so sad a situation that even getting a resting space on the

pavements is in itself a grueling ordeal. The pavement dwellers are even afraid lest they be accused of occupying too much space.

Through Munoo, we are also given a glimpse of the gross exploitation of the lowly by the bigger industries. When Munoo takes up a job at Sir George White's Cotton Mill, he is exposed to the full might of not only industrial but also colonial exploitation. In such big factories, we are shown the pitiable conditions under which the labourers work. They are always battered and insulted for no reason.

The British management offers the poor workers no security of tenure. Thus, they can be retrenched summarily as per the whims of the authorities. The same exploitative employers are the landlords who own and rent out to the workers, at exorbitant rent, dilapidated shanties. The same employers are the money-lenders

who charge the poor labourers high interest. These imperialist employers are so clever yet callously egoistic that when they get wind of an impending workers strike, they easily break the strike by instigating a religious clash between the Hindus and Muslims. It is while running away from a bloody scene during this Hindu-Muslim feud that Munoo is knocked down by the car of an Anglo-Indian, Mrs. Mainwaring. Mrs. Mainwaring takes Munoo to Simla where she treats him and then makes him her servant.

The episodes in Simla mark the fifth and final phase in the odyssey of Munoo. Munoo works both as Mrs. Mainwaring's domestic servant and rickshaw-puller. There is also a yawning insinuation that Munoo may also have been used by his employer as her sexual tool. As a rickshaw-puller, the poor boy is made to work hard, pulling rickshaw uphill for long hours till his energy is sapped. He develops tuberculosis, which is exacerbated by the rickshaw pulling and he begins to cough out blood. Finally, Munoo dies at the age of sixteen.

Through the loosely attached adventures of Munoo, Anand gives us an elaborate panoramic tour of India. Indeed, all the episodes are related only in as far as Munoo is concerned. Through Munoo's many escapades, Mulk Raj Anand effectively illuminates the misery of the Indian masses.

8.3 Epistolary Novel

If an *Epistle* means a *letter*, then the *epistolary* novel uses letters to communicate its message. One writer may write to another real or abstract character.

A good example of an epistolary novel is Mariama Ba's *So long a Letter*. This novel consists of letters written by two characters: Ramatoulaye and her friend Aissatou. Another example of an epistolary novel is Alice Walker's *The Color Purple*. In the largest part of this novel, the main character, Celie, addresses the supernatural (God) in her letters.

Because a letter is usually personal, the epistolary form has the advantage of giving an author an avenue to present the deepest felt emotions of the characters. In a letter, especially to a very close friend or relative, a person will easily pour out his/her heart without any inhibitions. This is what we see in the exchanges between Ramatoulaye and Aissatou. Being alter egos, they have nothing to hide from each other regarding their marital woes.

8.4 Historical Novel

A historical novel recreates the past. It alludes to and recounts historical occurrences through fictional characters. What this means is that a historical novel does not simply give a genuine picture of the past events or experiences. The use of varied fictional personages and the varied impact the historical events have on them, enable writers to give a fresh creative personal mark to a factual past.

Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye admirably weaves the historical and the fictional in *Coming to Birth*. Macgoye explores the lives of Martin and Paulina hand in hand with the history and development of the Kenyan nation. As the nation grows so does the initially immature couple mature. Macgoye narrates many historical events parallel with the development of her main characters. Thus, through these fictional characters, we get a feeling of: the state of emergency in Kenya, the attainment of independence, Mzee Kenyatta's 1969 Kisumu visit and the subsequent shootings, the assassinations of Tom Mboya and J.M. Kariuki. In a nutshell, we are

given a concrete history of Kenya for a period spanning more than two decades. At the end of *Coming to Birth*, we have not just seen Martin and Paulina but also the country Kenya struggling to mature.

8.5 Political Novel

Politics involves the ordering of men in society. A novel whose subject is such ordering is explicitly *political* in nature. All of Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's novels are

essentially political. For instance, in *The River Between*, Ngugi begins by evoking the sense of peace and harmony that prevailed in the ridges before the encroachment of the white man. Indeed, the villagers see the intrusion of the white person as a threat to peace and harmony. This is the same way Achebe in *Things Fall Apart*, views the coming of the white man to Africa. According to Achebe, the white man's invasion of Africa made the traditional African set-up "fall apart". "Things fall apart" because the white man dispossesses Africans of their land, treats them like vermin, on their own soil, indoctrinates them into believing in their own inferiority. It therefore calls for sacrifice on the part of Africans in order to achieve both political and mental liberty. This theme of sacrifice is what Ngugi addresses in *A Grain of Wheat*. While lashing at the whites for dislocating the African society, Achebe also takes the opportunity to criticize certain aspects of the traditional African socio-political system that facilitated the defection of the African to the white man's ways and consequently, the entrenchment of the white man in the African continent. Achebe questions the validity of rigid African customs that emphasize so much on achievement and high station to the extent of dehumanizing its own members against fellow members. Achebe also draws our attention to the cruelty of traditional political customs that demand the killing (sacrifice) of an innocent boy (like Ikemefuna).

(e) Sociological Novel

A *sociological* novel is interested in the problems of human life. These problems could be political, moral, economic or religious. In a nutshell, a sociological novel centers on and seeks to resolve social problems. For example, among other problems, Mariama Ba's *So Long a Letter* seeks to address the problem of male chauvinism which essentially gives rise to ill-treatment and discrimination of women by men.

Meja Mwangi's novel *Kill Me Quick* addresses the problem of unemployment. Yusuf Dawood's novels such as *Water Under the Bridge*, focus on the impact of diseases on individuals, families and society at large. Alex la Guma's novels such as *In the Fog of the Seasons' End* address the question of racism and its concomitant social evils.

8.6 Psychological Novel

A *psychological* novel is more interested in what goes on in a character's mind. Such a novel therefore recounts the inner experiences of a character. By exploring the sub-conscious life of a character, a psychological novel aims to explain the thoughts, beliefs, interior motives and mental circumstances that necessitated external action. Dostoevsky and Tolstoy wrote some of the best psychological novels. Novels like *Brothers Karamazov*, *Crime and Punishment* and *The Idiot* (all by Dostoevsky) and *Anna Karenina* (Tolstoy) cannot make much sense except by endeavouring to explore and apprehend the mental disposition of the characters. Locally, Ngugi Wa Thiong'o is one of the best Psychological writers. For example, his novel *A Grain of Wheat* is intrinsically psychological. Right from the beginning, it is obvious that the major characters are somehow puzzling. Their behaviour can only be described as bewildering.

For instance Mugo appears an introverted, alienated and nervous person. It is also apparently clear that he is keeping some secret to himself and this secret is tormenting him. Gikonyo also seems haunted by a past incident. Karanja is also extremely angry and disappointed. Such a psychological make-up necessitates a focus on these characters inner lives rather than on their outward behaviour. We may only fully understand these characters by entering into their hearts and minds. Ngugi Wa Thiong'o has to employ effective techniques that will enable him explore the minds of these characters in order for the reader to fathom their internal conflicts and dilemma. In this endeavour, Ngugi employs many stream of consciousness techniques. Consequently, we come to learn of Mugo's betrayal of Kihika, Gikonyo's betrayal of an oath and Karanja's anger, hurt and mental state due to losing Mumbi to Gikonyo. The author works consciously to guide and

manipulate our responses to the characters' actions. Ngugi penetrates these characters' past from all directions in order to explain their mental disposition.

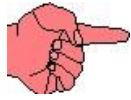
By the time the writer elucidates on the source of the characters' moral dilemmas and internal conflicts, we have been given enough information to appreciate and empathize with the characters in spite of their moral failures.

8.7 Epic Novel

Just like any other *epic form*, the *epic novel* recounts the adventures of heroic protagonists whose actions are of historical and legendary significance. Because the central character in an epic is so imposing, the setting of an epic novel is not a narrow one covering just a village even if that is all it seems at a literal level. The setting of an epic is usually vast – national or global in nature. The deeds of an epic hero are so important that they interest the supernatural forces. Ngugi's *The River Between* is an example of an epic novel. The novel is not just about a character known as Waiyaki. The original title of this novel "The Black Messiah" clearly indicates Waiyaki's role in this story. Just like Jesus Christ or Moses in the Bible, Waiyaki is tailor-made to fulfill a prophecy; to unchain his people.

Designed to be an epic hero, Waiyaki evolves as a unique child who exhibits leadership qualities. In line with the idea of a mythical component as a crucial aspect of the epic form, Ngugi Wa Thiong'o places Waiyaki against the larger canvass of a greatly ritualized Gikuyu world where the supernatural being shares certain attributes with human beings. Therefore, right from his childhood, Waiyaki is associated with sacred places. And if an epic character is typically a person of national stature, Waiyaki is not just a liberator of the ridges, he symbolizes all the Kenyans and world revolutionaries who, prompted by their simple faith in and love for fellow humanity, sacrificed their lives in order to liberate their brothers and sisters.

Note



- (i) The novel types discussed here are not exhaustive. There are many other forms such as: tragic, satirical, tragicomic, comic, e.t.c. You may read about these forms from your secondary reading texts.
- (ii) Also, it is common for a novel to exhibit more than one form. An epistolary novel could have political or historical themes. A historical novel could be psychological or political at the same time. An episodic novel is capable of demonstrating epic qualities. Therefore, these classifications are purely academic. Such categorization ease scholastic analysis.

8.8 Summary



In this lecture, we looked at several types of novels. We enumerated the unique characteristics of each form in order to distinguish the various forms. We also looked at practical examples of and from literary works in order to make the manifestations of the different kinds clear.

8.9 Activity

Q: Where would you classify any one of the following Kenyan novels and why?

- (a) *The River and the Source* – Margaret Ogola
- (b) *Jail Bugs* – Wahome Mutahi
- (c) *Ripples in the Pool* or *The Sacred Tree* – Rebeka Njau
- (d) *The Strange Bride* – Grace Ogot
- (e) *Shrine of Tears* – Francis Imbuga
- (f) *Homing In* - Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye

LESSON NINE

NON-FICTIONAL PROSE: the Biography, Autobiography, Memoirs, Diaries, Journals and Essays

9.0 Introduction

In this ninth lecture, we will focus on literary prose forms that are not innately fictional in their subject matter. These forms are discussed as literary genres only when imagination rather than plain actuality is also employed in weaving them. The extent and manner of creativity may be vast and manifold depending on the objectives geared at by the author.

9.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Describe the non-fictional prose forms.
2. Explain why they can be studied as literary genres.
3. Trace the historical development of these prose forms.

9.2 Autobiography

An *autobiography* is a writing about oneself. That is, the author of an autobiography is usually the subject and object of the work. Although little studied, the autobiography is an old genre of literature that gained recognition in the eighteenth century. In America, the autobiography came with independence. Literary scholars have even linked the notion and attributes of liberty (selfhood and authority) to the structure of the autobiographical form. In Europe, the autobiography also emerged at a time of political turbulence.

If literature is about imagination, why would a factual story of an author be considered literary? We need to appreciate that while it is easy to write about oneself, it is at the same time difficult. Whereas one easily draws from readily available material (true-life happenings), one may forget certain traumatic experiences. Sometimes, owing to the fact that human beings have a need for secrecy, then ‘forgetting’ may be simply motivated since personal secrets are closely linked to our knowledge of personal esteem. Therefore, we may not want to say everything about ourselves lest we be embarrassed. Indeed, the autobiographer cannot ignore the psychological principle of secrecy and embarrassment. This means that although as a study of both the social and psychological processes the autobiography is candid, it is somehow ‘fictional’ to the extent that as far as the truth is concerned, the author is not always frank.

Given that the autobiographical author seeks to elicit favourable responses from the reader, he cautiously chooses a favourable perspective from which he confronts his past. He may subvert certain issues or simply ignore or suppress some facts. When an autobiographer attacks himself, he does it in such a way that guarantees sympathy and admiration. For example in Ezekiel Mphahlele’s *Down Second Avenue*, the author tells us that as children, him and his brother used to steal the neighbours’ pigs and chicken. They also used to adulterate the neighbours’ milk by urinating in it. However, these uncouth truths are delivered to us in a slanted and flattering manner: that these are youth-like ‘birthright’ adventures; a source of fun; jolly escapades. An autobiography is therefore notoriously subjective.

Self-portraiture is perhaps the hardest of all art. Is it you as perceived by yourself or you as seen by people? So we select and discriminate. An autobiography therefore relies on selection of appropriate language (creative language) on the presentation of self. On experiences, the autobiographer innovatively reconstructs

a portrait of himself and also ingeniously organizes his experiences. These structural and character recreations together with linguistic resourcefulness are what elevate the autobiography to the podium of a literary genre.

Also, most literary autobiographies are universal in nature to the extent that just like novels, they focus on the particular (author) with a view to expressing the general (social) concerns. It is a fact that most African autobiographies were written during the time of political transitions or struggles. For example, *Down Second Avenue* is not just Mphahlele's story. Rather, through Mphahlele, this autobiographical novel throws light on the plight of the black people under an apartheid regime. Mphahlele is writing about the South Africa of the 1950s, particularly, about the experiences of the urbanized blacks that were grouped in slums as equals. These experiences are situated within the context of apartheid; they are not just about the author.

The autobiography has the merits of creating a sense of immediacy. The first person narrative employed gives the author absolute authority over the facts of his writing. What this means is that the reader easily believes the writer and can therefore be easily persuaded or prejudiced into taking a particular standpoint. Up to now, the most popular and widely read African autobiographical novel remains Camara Laye's *The African Child*. Originally written in French, *The African Child* is the autobiography of a boy who was born at Kouroussa, in French Guinea, a country with an old civilization in which the ancient ritualistic society of the Malinke has remained alive. This novel has the force of the nostalgia that inspired Laye to write it in order to relieve his homesickness at a time when he was in exile far away from his people.

9.3 Memoirs, Diaries/Journals

Although considered subsets of the autobiography, memoirs, diaries, journals and even literary letters are yet to be acknowledged locally as literary genres. This is because these forms essentially subsist on dire fact rather than imagination. Local scholars are yet to endeavour to explore the artistic aspects of these forms. The reason for this lack of recognition also springs from the fact that memoirs, diaries, journals and letters are either non-existent in a published form or negligible in number. In Western countries where such prose forms have been published in volumes, they have been studied as art. However, such studies still remain insignificant.

Memoirs

This is an autobiographical writing that records the recollections of notable people and public experiences. This means that unlike the autobiography proper which totally focuses on the self, in *memoirs* the author does not purely focus on himself as the subject of the story. Rather, the author as witness and (or) participant, recounts public events and actions of prominent personalities.

Diary/Journal

A diary/journal is a form of the autobiography which records the writer's daily physical and emotional events. It recounts what the writer did or experienced bodily day by day and also what may have transpired in his mind owing to the physical occurrences. In recent days, the diary is obtaining a conscious literary form.

9.4 Biography

A *biography* is a writing by one person about another person's life. The biographer centers wholly on the life and character of his subject. Again, not all biographies are literary. A literary scholar will therefore only be interested in a biography that deliberately employs the linguistic resources of fiction in a manner that transforms fact into art: imaginative and pleasurable. Literally, the term biography demands that the biographer must be historically authentic and accurately present all facets of the subject. That notwithstanding, these demands have not always been adhered to. If the biography sprung from the innately human urge to commemorate important people in the writer's life (such as mother, father, husband or wife) or public life (liberation heroes, presidents, Nobel prize winners, greatest sportsmen, musicians or actors), it logically follows that the writer may tend to focus only on the virtues of his subject, overlooking the vices.

9.5 The Literary Essay

An *essay* is a genre in prose that is not fiction. It is a moderately short argument/debate/discussion of a restricted theme. An essay is autobiographical in the sense that it presents the writer's personal position regarding a topic.

However, an essay acquires seriousness from the salience of its theme and dignified purpose of its author.

A *literary essay* is characterized by literary use of language, often colloquial. A literary essay is therefore different from a critical essay which conventionally uses formal language: dry and intellectual. A literary essay is subjective, based on the writer's experience. Fundamentally, the literary essay advances to discuss a matter from an author's opinion. In order to persuade his readers, a literary essayist employs language designed to influence the reader to empathize with him. Even though a literary essayist is not duty-bound to draw from facts in advancing his opinion, good essay writers logically construct their essays in order to convince.

Critical essays are essays about literature or particular literary texts. Whereas they discuss literary material, they should not be mistaken for being literary themselves. Critical essays are purely scholarly, formal, objective and survive only because literature exists. Critical essays are important to the growth of literature in the sense that they aim at correcting works of art. Critical essays are generally direct in addressing issues. On the other hand *literary essays* are rhetorical (that is, they reveal imaginative use of language aimed at persuasion) and subjective. Literary essays may simply entertain. Unlike critical essays, which draw their livelihood from literary texts, literary essays exist just because life exists. A literary essayist writes on any subject or experience of life.

Some of the best critical essays on African literature are found in Eldred Durosimi Jones' (editor) series of *African Literature Today*. Chinua Achebe has also written his various views on literature in several critical essays found in his books *Hopes and Impediments* and *Morning Yet on Creation Day*. Locally, we have works like Chris

Wanjala's (editor) *Standpoints on African Literature* and Micere Mugo's *Visions of Africa*. Ngugi Wa Thiong'o has also written numerous critical essays found in: *Decolonizing the Mind*, *Writers in Politics*, *Homecoming*, and *Moving the Centre*.

Having made clear the distinction between literary and critical essays, we need to look at a practical example of a literary essay. Jonathan Swift is one renowned writer who wrote essays that could be termed as literary because of their satiric form. See how Swift exposes the desperate state of Ireland by lashing at the exploitative English government in an indirect yet horrifying manner in the following essay entitled "A Modest Proposal":

It is a melancholy object to those who walk through this great town, or travel in the country, when they see the streets, the roads and cabin-doors crowded with beggars of the female sex, followed by three, four or six children, all in rags, and importuning every passenger for an alms. These mothers, instead of being able to work for their honest livelihood, are forced to employ all their time in strolling, to beg sustenance for their helpless infants, who, as they grow up, either turn thieves for want of work, or leave their dear native country to fight for the Pretender in Spain, or sell themselves to the Barbadoes.

I think it is agreed by all parties that this prodigious number of children, in the arms, or on the backs, or at the heels of their mothers, and frequently of their fathers, is in the present deplorable state of the kingdom a very great additional grievance; and therefore whoever could find out a fair, cheap, and easy method of making these children sound useful members of the commonwealth would deserve so well of the public as to have his statue set up for a preserver of the nation.

But my intention is far from being confined to provide only for the children or professed beggars; it is of a much greater extent, and shall take in the whole number of infants at a certain age who are born of parents in effect as little able to support them as those who demand our charity in the streets.

As to my own part, having turned my thoughts for many years upon this important subject, and maturely weighed the several schemes of other projectors, I have always found them grossly mistaken in their computation. It is true a child just dropped from its

dam may be supported by her milk for a solar year with little other nourishment, at most not above the value of two shilling, which the mother may certainly get, or the value in scraps, by her lawful occupation of begging, and it is exactly one year old that I propose to provide for them, in such a manner as, instead of being a charge upon their parents, or the parish, or wanting food and raiment for the rest of their lives, they shall, on the contrary, contribute to the feeding and partly to the clothing of many thousands.

There is likewise another great advantage in my scheme, that it will prevent those voluntary abortions, and that horrid practice of women murdering their bastard children, alas, too frequent among us, sacrificing the poor innocent babes, I doubt, more to avoid the expense than the shame, which would move tears and pity in the most savage and inhuman breast.

The number of souls in Ireland being usually reckoned one million and a half, of these I calculate there may be about two hundred thousand couples whose wives are breeders, from which number I subtract thirty thousand couples who are able to maintain their own children, although I apprehend there cannot be so many under the present distresses of the kingdom, but this being granted, there will

remain an hundred and seventy thousand breeders. I

again subtract fifty thousand for those women who miscarry, or whose children die by accident or disease within the year. There only remain an hundred and twenty thousand children of poor parents annually born: the question therefore is, how this number shall be reared, and provided for, which, as I have already said, under the present situation of affairs is utterly impossible by all the methods hitherto proposed, for we can neither employ them in handicraft or agriculture; we neither build houses (I mean in the country), nor cultivate land: they can very seldom pick up a livelihood by stealing until they arrive at six years old, except where they are of towardly parts, although I confess they learn the rudiments much earlier, during which time they can however be properly looked upon only as probationers, as I have been informed by a principal gentleman in the County of Cavan, who protested to me that he never knew above one or two instances under the age of six, even in a part of the kingdom so renowned for the quickest proficiency in that art.

I am assured by our merchants that a boy or girl before twelve years old, is no saleable commodity, and even when they come to this age, they will not yield above three pounds, or three pounds and half-a-crown at most on the Exchange, which cannot turn to account either to the parents or the kingdom, the charge of nutriment and rags having been at least four times that value.

I shall now therefore humbly propose my own thoughts, which I hope will not be liable to the least objection.

I have been assured by a very knowing American of my acquaintance in London, that a young healthy child well nursed is at a year old most delicious, nourishing and wholesome food, whether stewed, roasted, baked or boiled, and I make no doubt that it will equally serve in a fricassee, or a ragout.

I do therefore humbly offer it to public consideration, that of the hundred and twenty thousand children already computed, twenty thousand may be reserved for breed, whereof only one fourth part to be males, which is more than we allow to sheep, black-cattle, or swine, and my reason is that these children are seldom the fruits of marriage, a circumstance not much regarded by our savages, therefore one male will be sufficient to serve four females. That the remaining hundred thousand may at a year old be offered in sale to the persons of quality, and fortune, through the kingdom, always advising the mother to let them suck plentifully in the last month, so as to render them plump, and fat for a good table. A child will make two dishes at an entertainment for friends, and when the family dines alone, the fore or hind quarter will make a reasonable dish, and seasoned with a little pepper or salt will be very good boiled on the fourth day, especially in winter...

I have already computed the charge of nursing a beggar's child (in which list I reckon all cottagers, labourers, and four-fifths of the farmers) to be about two shillings per annum, rags included, and I believe no gentleman would repine to give ten shillings for the carcass of a good fat child, which, as I have said, will make four dishes of excellent nutritive meat, when he hath only some particular friend or his family to dine with him. Thus the Squire will learn to be a good landlord and grow popular among his tenants, the mother will have eight shillings net profit, and be fit for work until she produces another child.

Those who are more thrifty (as I must confess the times require) may flay the carcass; the skin of which artificially dressed will make admirable gloves for ladies, and summer boots for fine gentlemen...

After all I am not so violently bent upon my own opinion as to reject any offer, proposed by wise men, which shall be found equally innocent, cheap, easy and effectual. But before some thing of that kind shall be advanced in contradiction to my scheme, and offering a better, I desire the author, or authors, will be pleased maturely to consider two points. First, as things now stand, how they will be able to find food and raiment for a hundred thousand useless mouths and backs? And secondly, there being a round million of creatures in human figure, throughout this kingdom, whose whole subsistence put into a common stock would leave them in debt two millions of pounds

sterling; adding those who are beggars in effect; I desire those politicians who dislike my overture, and may be perhaps be so bold to attempt an answer, that they will first ask the parents of these mortals whether they would not at this day think it a great happiness to have been sold for food at a year old, in the manner I prescribe, and thereby have avoided such a perpetual scene of misfortunes as they have since gone through, by the oppression of landlords, the impossibility of paying rent without money or trade, the want of common sustenance, with neither house nor clothes to cover them from the inclemencies of weather, and the most inevitable prospect of entailing the like, or greater miseries upon their breed for ever.

(A Modest Proposal for Preventing the Children of Poor People in Ireland from being a Burden to their Parents or Country and for making them Beneficial to the Public)

In the essay above, Jonathan Swift uses an appropriate literary form – **Satire** to press home the hopeless inadequacy of the economic policies in England. **Satire** is a literary device that is **cruel** and **kind** in the sense that it combines sharp, bitter, biting criticism with humour. Therefore satire *ridicules through laughter*. In the essay above, Swift expresses his anger at the miseries of the country he lived in, Ireland, in a shocking yet jocular manner. Imagine a situation where poor parents have to slaughter and sell their children; their greatest happiness, as a delicacy. Then swift ‘assumes’ that such a move will not only help control the population of the country but also contribute to the resources of the kingdom. Swift also ‘believes’ that the by-products of the children’s ‘carcasses’ will be useful and profitable as well. Such a proposal sounds outrightly insane, inhuman and impractical. Yet swift presents such a proposal as economically sound, practical and factual.

At a literary level, Swift is not really serious about his so called ‘modest’ proposal. Rather, Swift carefully chooses his language to shock his government and country men into seeing the consequences of their actions. His explicit suggestion is that if the people of Ireland can no longer maintain themselves owing to poor economic policies, they may as well try to make money and contribute to their country resources by killing and trading in their children. This is a scathing attack on a capitalistic country where the poor are seen as an embarrassment simply because

they contribute ‘nothing’ to their country. Swift’s argument is that if the poor are to be seen as an embarrassment just because they have no work, it may as well be okay to slaughter all their children to save them from the wretchedness that their lot is condemned to. Implicit in this argument is a scathing criticism of the inhumanity of public policies and private actions. At the end of the essay, we are able to visualize Swift’s great dismay due to the impact of the frightening proposal, which he conveys in an approach purposed to give an impression that he is seriously sincere. The calm tone with which the well selected satiric details of the horrifying proposed scheme is delivered, is well calculated to effectively express Swift’s great indignation for and disdain to the indifferent English government (and negligee landlords) while at the same time

shocking the authorities into awareness of the sorry state of the country. It is Swift’s objective that after bringing the powers-that-be into a state of recognition in a frightening manner, the authorities will put up measures to change the situation.

Activity



Discuss the literary merits of any essay of your choice.

9.6 Summary



In this lecture, we have looked at various forms of non-fictional prose. We have noted that although these forms are inherently ***non-fictional*** especially where facts regarding characterization and events are concerned, they acquire ***literariness*** when the writers *choose to imaginatively organize, exaggerate or subvert aspects of character and action*. Most importantly, such ‘factual’ prose forms obtain their aesthetic literariness from the linguistic manipulation employed which draws from literary style.

9.7Activity



- (i) Select any non-fictional prose form of your choice and identify features that make it qualify to be studied as an art form.
- (ii) With illustrations, compare and contrast two non-fictional prose forms.

LESSON TEN

DRAMA

as drama since they are real-life situations. So what is *drama*?

10.0 Introduction

This is the tenth lecture in this course. Having discussed prose forms in the last four lectures, we now turn to a different literary genre: drama.

In order to avoid repeating ourselves, in this lecture we will be interested more in the nature of drama that is peculiar to the genre. Whereas aspects that are universal to literature will be mentioned lest we forget that they are applicable to drama as well, we shall not devote much space and time to such features.

10.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define the word *drama* from a strictly literary perspective.
2. Define the general features of drama.
3. Give reasons for particular aspects of drama.

10.2 What is “Drama”?

The term *drama* has not been clearly understood. Think of the daily newspaper loose headline shouting: “Drama at Political Rally”, “Drama as Teachers go on Strike” or cry: “Highway Robbery Drama”. All these situations do not qualify. According to Aristotle, drama involves *enactment* – imitation of human action. Enactment entails a rehearsed presentation and not something happening there and then. Enactment also involves *impersonation*. What this means is that a

real life situation can never be drama. Drama is make-believe not reality. If politicians altercate and even exchange blows at a political rally, it is just that: a concrete commotion, embroilment, a row. However, one could take such a real situation and re-enact it on stage. Even the same/real characters can be used in the re-enactment but it would still remain drama as long as what they are acting is an imitation of what happened before - the politician (call him Mr. X) of 5.00 pm impersonating the Mr. X of 1.00 o'clock even though it is actually the same person.

Drama is derived from the Greek word “drans” which means ***action*** or ***performance*** and “drao” which means ***struggle*** or ***conflict***. Hence, we can say drama consists in action by or through struggle. The element of ‘action’ is the most central feature of drama. This means that drama has to be performed. A novel or short story satisfies itself even being read. The events in a novel or short story are narrated while in drama they are enacted. A novel does not cry for performance. Drama has to be dramatized – a song has to be sung in order for it to exist as a song. It is only through dramatization or singing that the text springs into life. However, that does not mean that a short story or even a novel cannot be dramatized. You can take a story or novel and adapt it on stage. Locally, the Free Traveling Theatre of the University of Nairobi has performed Chinua Achebe’s novel ***Things Fall Apart*** successfully. Globally we also have thousands of novels that have been dramatized in the form of movies or television series. Examples of these: include Charles Dickens’ novels like ***Great Expectations***, Jane Austen’s ***Pride and Prejudice***, Alice walker’s ***The Color Purple***, Alex Haley’s ***Roots*** and several of Kuki Gallman’s and Sidney Sheldon’s works, among many other dramatized prose fiction. Another way of dramatizing prose fiction has been through use of narrators. The narrator interprets the story for the audience using the same physical attributes that belong to the character in the story. Thus, the narrator becomes some sort of actor. A good narrator will tell the story dramatically. He/she will transform from his/her real self to the man or woman he/she is presenting in the story.

This transformation where a person fully imitates or acts the role of another person is what we call *impersonation*. In short stories and novels, we have *characters* not *actors*. Drama consists in the relationship between the ‘characters’ – the way they act and react to each other.

In terms of action, drama is *multi-medial*. What this means is that action in drama communicates its message through many forms of “action”. The action may be *audial/verbal* (spoken language, even silence), *visual* (physical action and even scenery) or *sensual* (emotional – from the actions, talks and scenery among other dramatic elements, our emotions are aroused).

Let us now look at particular elements of drama in a more elaborate manner:

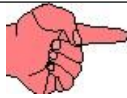
(i) Representation

We have already stated that drama entails re-enacting or imitating real-life situations and patterns. This re-enactment or acting is what we call *representation*. Aristotle argued that representation has more powerful impact than narration since the ear is aroused much more slowly than the eye. Indeed, if you want to arouse your audience faster, you would show them rather than tell them. It is more exciting and memorable to watch a play than to read a novel.

We are easily stirred by a dramatic performance because we get a feeling of actually witnessing the events. However, not everything ought to be shown on stage. For example, too much violence on stage will only shock rather than excite the audience. It would also appall the audience to get a real corpse, chop off its genitalia and stuff them in the corpse’s mouth and then parade such a body on stage just to ‘vividly’ represent the brigadier who in John Ruganda’s *The Floods*, is fished out of the lake by Kyeyune. Incidents of gruesome violence, death and sex ought only to be narrated lest they horrify or embarrass the audience.

Whereas the actions in a novel are presented in paragraphs and chapters, dramatic representation is divided in sections called *acts* and *scenes*. Representing events in a time locus, time passes within *acts* and *scenes* at different interval. *Acts* are the longer divisions of a play. The *acts* are often subdivided further into *scenes*. *Scenes* conventionally correspond to the important stages in the action of the play within the *act*. Really, such partitioning in drama is made to serve the meaning of the play.

Note



- (1) Note all plays must have acts and scenes. Some plays can simply have one act. These are generally thematically concentrated short plays lasting anything from fifteen to fifty minutes.
- (2) Whereas traditional Greek drama employs no act or scene divisions, choruses recite songs in between the pauses in the actions.

Activity



Read Francis Imbuga's *Betrayal in the City* or John Ruganda's *The Burdens* and answer the following questions:

- (1) Why has the writer partitioned the acts and scenes the way he did?
- (2) Do the various sections (acts and scenes) correspond to the development and overall meaning of the play?

(ii) Plot

When we discussed the prose forms, we defined **plot** as a logical sequence of events. The same definition applies to drama. The dramatic plot will tell you what characters do and explain why. Showing how one thing leads to another, a dramatic plot is responsible for the development of conflict in a play. What makes a dramatic plot different from any other plot is the fact that **dramatic plot does not merely narrate but rather, acts out**. That is, a dramatic plot is seen when issues are performed for the audience to see.

In traditional drama there was a conventional plot structure divided into five parts: (a) Introduction or exposition, (b) Complication or rising action, (c) Climax or turning point, (d) Falling action and (e) Resolution/denouement. In the first part, the source of the conflict would be explained. **The exposition** created the tone, introduced characters and provided any other detail necessary to understanding the nature of the dramatic conflict in the play. The **complication** developed the conflict of the forces involved. The **climax** would signal the turning point in the actions of

a play. Whereas there was a rising movement in the actions of the play in the first two parts, with the climax, the play began to take a falling movement. When the *falling action* begun, the dramatic plot endeavoured to resolve the conflict. The *denouement* eventually solved the mystery or conflict in the play.

(iii) The language of drama

Language is a system of or code for communication that may be verbal or nonverbal, literal or non-literal. Unlike other genres of literature, which use only the literal (written and oral), drama communicates through both the literal and non- literal (non-lingual or extra-lingual) features.

Literal or verbal language in drama involves the spoken word and also includes silence. But verbal language in ordinary life does not come in isolation. Certain words invite the speaker to use certain gestures. Gestures are non-verbal aspects of communication. It is the combination of both verbal (speech) and nonverbal (gestures) that helps make the meaning forceful or clear. Verbal language therefore transcends itself in drama to reveal something which may not be spoken. For instance, gestures can be used to express attitudes like love or contempt more strongly than mere words. Words may also invite certain action or movement. If an actor shouts at another to “GET OUT!” we expect either the addressee to refuse and perhaps argue vehemently against such an order or simply leave obsequiously without shouting back: “I AM GOING OUT!”. The verbal word/dialogue in a play is complemented by action.

Non-verbal language in drama also includes: costume, lighting and setting. You may tell a mad person just from the costumes – unkempt hair or scruffy wig and haggard clothing, worn inside out, or no clothing at all (if at all this can be effectively acted without the risk of upsetting both actor and audience). You may also tell a king from his royal robes, a priest from the white collar and a policeman from his uniform. The furniture in a house will give you a clue as to whether the owner is

wealthy or impoverished. Non-verbal aspects of communication are grounded in spectacle and cultural codes. We are able to discern the characters and location through seeing.

Sometimes the non-verbal features can be employed to contradict the verbal. A character may brag about being intelligent and yet do things that can only be termed idiotic. Or a man declares that he is affluent yet is seen on stage in cheap clothing and patched shoes.

Non-verbal language in drama may also involve *physical symbols*. Symbols in drama can be both verbal and non-verbal. For example, a chair may represent a kingdom. Costumes are sometimes symbolic of the characters' social status in the world of the play. We also have universal symbols like: flags (nations), roses (love), doves (peace) and many more.

The playwright carefully selects whatever mode of expression and uses it purposefully. The main factor that necessitates this careful selection in drama is the limited space within which the playwright operates. Whereas the novelist has ample room to describe what a character or setting looks like, the playwright expects that this picture will be created through the actor's body, costume, make-up, scenery and lighting effects. Elements of non-verbal language are usually captured through stage direction. Since drama tries to recreate human situations on stage rather than describe them, compared to prose fiction, drama is more economical in its means of communication.

Verbal language in drama helps to *individualize characters*. By giving characters distinct dialects or speech patterns, the author enables the audience to easily identify a character. The dialogue of characters in drama is also marked by features of impromptu language that we discussed under dialogue in prose fiction. Such features include: pauses, redundancy, syntactic mistakes, intonations and exclamations. Because the action in drama is presented as happening there and then on stage, the language is usually marked by use of active verbs and interrogatives.

The movement of dramatic dialogue is generally fairly fast. This is because drama typically employs shorter sentences subsequent to the fact that drama imitates the language of everyday. In normal conversations, it is not humanly possible, at the spur of a moment, to come up with the very long, sometimes one-page sentences that a novelist like Charles Dickens affords to use in his prose fiction.

Let us look at a practical example of the behaviour of some of these verbal features we have just mentioned:

Kaija: Where is father's spear?
Tinka: He took it.
Kaija: Not during the emergency? Tinka:
He took it.
Kaija: I can see blood.
Tinka: (frightened, quickly checks her dress) Where?
Kaija: Horrible stains of blood.
Tinka: (sharply) Where?
Kaija: Here, there, everywhere.
Tinka: Where? Show me.
Kaija: If father goes out with a spear, what do you expect?

This is an example of a fast paced scene where the short sentences and interrogatives enhance the rapid movement thereby bringing out the ecstasy characterizing the scene between Kaija and Tinka.

The verbal language of drama has the **text** (or what you may simply call the explicit or overt meaning of the words) and the **sub-text** (that is, the covert or implied meaning). The sub-text is usually read between the lines. Sub-texts are sometimes marked by asides, soliloquies, cross-purpose conversations and digressions, among other dramatic devices. A sub-text is better revealed by actors on stage as they try to enact the character's inner life. You must therefore seek clues to inner feelings of characters from dialogue and stage directions in order to get the correct inferences. One stylistic element that distinguishes John
Ruganda's plays is his extensive use of dramatic asides and cross-purpose dialogue. Whereas the use of digressions, asides, cross-purpose conversation and soliloquies

may sometimes seem unrelated to the central story line, these aspects certainly do not only diversify the writer's fictional world but also reveal the characters' unspoken thoughts and feelings. For instance, through these structural elements, we learn a lot about the inner lives of major characters like Bwogo and Nankya (*The Floods*) and Tinka and Wamalwa (*The Burdens*).

Activity

Q: "Dramatic language is both verbal and non-verbal". Discuss with illustrations from any play of your choice.

(iv) Characterization

Since we have already talked about characterization elsewhere (see under the novel and short story genres), we will not repeat ourselves here. That notwithstanding, we need to point out the uniqueness of characterization in drama. From your reading of drama, you may have noticed that the character in a play is portrayed rather quickly such that within a short time you understand virtually all the attributes of the character. In ordinary life, we get to know a person fully after many weeks, months or years of being in close contact with each other. However, the playwright does not have the space for such gradual portrayal of character. Therefore the concentration that marks the limited space at a playwright's disposal, explains the rapid character depiction.

Characters in drama communicate more readily than in real life even if it be at cross-purpose. Irrelevancies and empty digressions are usually either totally absent or extremely pared down, almost insignificant.

We learn about characters in drama as in life through four basic means:

(a) What a character does and says

A character's action to others and himself, what he says about himself and what he says to and about others, his views about issues; all these enable us to judge the traits of the character. We easily get to know Tumbo's moral bankruptcy in Francis Imbuga's ***Betrayal in the City*** when he remarks that "Education does not matter these days" (p.45). To him, the amount of money that one has and the people in authority that one knows, are all that counts. With money and influential relatives and friends, Tumbo believes one should be able to attain all his goals; get all that he desires. Tumbo therefore comes out as a person who favours corruption to merit.

(b) What other characters say about a particular character and their actions towards this character.

We also learn about a character from what other characters say about him. In Imbuga's ***Betrayal in the City***, we do not meet Adika at all since when the actions of the play begin, Adika is already dead. However, we learn so much about him from what characters like Mosese and Jusper say about him. Likewise, although in John Ruganda's ***The Floods*** we never meet Boss in person, we get to make out a lot about him from what the characters say about him.

We also learn a lot about the two main characters

(Bwogo and Nankya) from what they say about each other.

The manner in which characters treat or act towards each other also speaks volumes about the characters. We can easily tell Mulili's dictatorial and condescending attitude in ***Betrayal in the City*** when he commands "every movable adult to line the road" just to welcome a state visitor. This is also an act of hypocrisy intended to give the state visitor an impression of unity and peace in Kafira.

(c) What the writer says about the character

Playwrights usually vary or contrast their characters with the sole purpose of making their meaning clear. In ***Betrayal in the City***, the masses like Doga and Nina and intellectuals like Mosese and Jusper are contrasted with egoistic leaders such as Mulili, Tumbo and Kabito. The leaders, who revel in power mania and selfishness, are the primary beneficiaries of independence whereas the majority of common persons and even intellectuals, who deserve a share of the national cake, wallow in misery, are totally overwhelmed with brutality and some of them (like Doga and Nina) have lost hope.

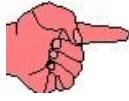
Through character contrast, we are able to judge the actors and ethically as human beings, we will side with the good characters.

(d) What kind of situation the character acts or speaks Under

The circumstances under which a character speaks will tell you a lot about the character. For example, Mosese in ***Betrayal in the City*** comes out as a fearless, assertive person. Despite being jailed for political reasons, he can still

afford to remain frank and bold when talking to the Askari. Mosese's political awakening and unshakeable resolve is positive in the sense that it points to a brighter future where the enlightened citizen will fearlessly demand for all his rights. Mosese's political consciousness indicates Imbuga's attempts to awaken the people.

Note



To be able to understand a character fully, it is also very important to note the following:

(1)

The names of the character – Sometimes playwrights or literary writers generally, give their characters names that say a lot about them (characters). For example ‘Tumbo’ (stomach) in ***Betrayal in the City*** is indicative of greed. ‘Boss’, in the same play, is not a leader *per se* but well above his subjects such that he only dictates or *bosses* them. An example of symbolic names in prose would be found in Charles Dickens ***Hard Times***. In this novel, M’choakumchild is not just a teacher’s name. Rather, M’choakumchild is one teacher who is out to choke the child with scientific facts. It is therefore very important to pay attention to the name of a literary character.

(3) ***The role of the character*** – It is important to note the position the character plays in his society. Is he a mayor, a district commissioner, a housewife, a university professor, a student or just a common man? Usually, drama revolves around the position the characters play in their various fictional worlds.

(4) ***How old is a character?*** - A literary writer will deliberately describe or specify the age of a character in order to make his meaning clear. For example in ***The Burdens***, Ruganda consciously presents Kaija and Nankya as children in order to effectively demonstrate the impact of the socio-political realities on children in his creative world.

Activity

List the main characters involved in Francis Imbuga's *Betrayal in the City* or *Aminata* or any Kenyan play of your choice and qualify their roles in the play.

(v) Theme/thought

While discussing novels, we said that themes are the ideas, primary or secondary, expressed in a literary work. ***Thought*** in serious literature is normally governed by the notion of social morality. Good acts are applauded while wicked acts are condemned.

Theme in drama is expressed in several ways. Firstly, theme is expressed through the rhetoric of dialogue. Through the conversation of the actors, we may discern the likes and dislikes of the author. Speech shows the character's preferences and it is from these preferences that we may judge a character as moral or otherwise.

Secondly, since drama is a cognitive process in the sense that a dramatist consciously seeks to create concrete or abstract concepts understandable to his audience, a playwright shapes various ideas/themes through deliberate creation of *situations* in which characters exist. The actor of a play is therefore charged with the responsibility of giving faithful interpretation or enactment of the character's action or reaction within the *situation*. On the other hand, the audience has to react to the actor's rendition of a character's reaction, on stage, to his/her situation.

In other words, theme in drama is dependent upon performance whereas performance presupposes the existence of both the performer and the audience.

The role of the audience is important because the audience endeavours to decode what is being presented on stage so as to make meaning. This is done on the basis of the audience's experience in life. The audience accepts or recognizes what is being presented on stage as familiar or not. For example when Jumba in Imbuga's *Aminata* jumps out of bed and pleads with an invisible being to leave him alone, this scene makes sense only because we are familiar with dreaming and the idea of ghosts. Jumba's behaviour indicates that he is either dreaming or has been confronted by a spirit. His words also suggest that he has assented to the demands of the ghost. Jumba agrees to "knock down the cement" (p.62) on the grave and hand over the controversial piece of land to Aminata. The ghost therefore creates a change of attitude in Jumba. It arouses in him the realization that change is inevitable.

Familiarity in drama therefore means that the playwright, actor and audience share a common knowledge that makes the audience understand the message of a dramatic performance. However, by accepting what happens in the world of drama, it does not mean that what goes on is true. The process is that of *recognition*. If what goes on on stage is real or not will mean accepting the action or situation or rethinking / questioning the abnormality of the action on the part of the audience. Some of the collective reactions of the audience become manifested to the audience itself through laughter or applause. The basic notion here is that if the audience comprises of individuals, then it can be argued that they have the same thought (thematic understanding) in their minds as regards the actions on stage and they also experience almost the same emotion. These emotions are stimulated by the *familiar* theme being expressed on stage by the performers.

Whether an audience likes or dislikes a performance can be felt by both the actor on stage and the audience itself as they fidget and lose concentration or applaud in unison.

Whereas a solitary reader of a play may not laugh uproariously or cry silently, it is

nonetheless important for him to recognize the humour or melancholy in the written work as one would in a live performance.

When a fine play is staged, the spontaneous laughter, involuntary tongue-clicking of disapproval or impulsive cries of “aahs” and “oohs” of wonder and awe lead to more concentration among the audience and also encourage debate among the audience as they walk out at the end of the show. These kinds of debates yield more spiritual insight into the issues raised by the performance. In essence, both the actor and audience, and indeed, the originator of the drama – the playwright – share collective experiences. Since human beings are social animals living together as a family, clan tribe or nation, they inevitably share common experiences and as such they are identifiable as a social group defined in terms of shared common customs, beliefs, concepts, language, myths, laws and rules of social decorum. It is in this regard that Imbuga’s or Ruganda’s plays would impact more on an East African audience than let’s say, a Canadian audience that is not only ignorant of the East African political scenario, but also the traditions and culture of East Africans. For example, the idea of superstition that pervades Imbuga’s *Aminata* and Ruganda’s *The Floods*, superstition that even links impotence (Jumba in *Aminata*) to uprooting a sacred tree and superstition that associates disaster to desecrating a traditional god (Nyamgondho in *The Floods*) may sound like utter claptrap and absolute lunacy to a European. Vice-versa may also be true – things which are dear to the Westerners may sound as ridiculous to Africans.

Even though drama involves the collective, at the same time, owing to personal encounters, the individual audience experiences his or her own identity. This is because like in all genres of literature, dramatic action imitates aspects of life. This imitation usually affects the audience collectively while at the same time touching on our individual emotions and eliciting personal reactions depending on our life experiences.

On the issue of ‘*aspects of life*’, Imbuga’s *Aminata* is a play that was purposively intended by the author to give a different perspective of the African woman at a time when the African woman was virtually overlooked. Although *Aminata* also explores other themes, women liberation is its central theme. Imbuga’s message is that a woman

has potential and that given a chance she is capable of accomplishing any task that a man is able to do. Aminata does chores that would traditionally be identified with men. She brings piped water to the village, she educates her drunken brother's children, and she even buys her father's coffin.

Note

Because drama is realized in performance, one may only fully understand the themes and feelings attendant to these ideas in a play when the play is acted. However, since you may not always get the opportunity to watch a course text performed live on stage or on video, in your reading of the text, you should try as much as possible to read the text loudly, enacting it as you read. This method helps to make the events and ideas in the play vivid and memorable.

10.3 Summary

In this lecture we have explained in details the features of plays and dramatic performances. We have concentrated more on the aspects unique to drama. We began by defining the word drama by detailing its basic nature. We then looked at features of language, plot, characterization and theme.

10.4 Activity

- (i) Referring to the physical actions or dialogue in any East African play of your choice, show how any central themes are revealed.
- (ii) With illustrations, discuss how drama is a reflection of society.

LESSON ELEVEN

TYPES OF DRAMA

11.0 Introduction

In our tenth lecture we talked about features of drama. We described those aspects that separate drama from other genres of literature. Nevertheless, drama is in itself not homogenous. Drama also has sub-genres within it. Various dramatic forms tend to ‘behave’ differently from others. Their ‘behaviour’ is really determined by their function. In this eleventh lecture, we are going to talk about various forms of drama and their uniqueness.

11.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Identify various forms of drama.
2. Describe their features.
3. Give reasons for their distinct features

11.2 Tragedy

A tragic play recounts the events in the life of an important person. The person rises then falls. The fall is characterized by conflict and disaster. *Tragedy* therefore describes the fall of this hero from the pinnacle or pick of life. We have said that a tragedy involves an important person. Now, who is an important person? In Greek and classical drama such a person would be isolated from society mainly by his higher status. For example Oedipus in Sophocles *King Oedipus* is a prince, then king. Othello in Shakespeare’s *Othello* is a prince.

King Lear in Shakespeare's *King Lear* is a king. Coriolanus in Shakespeare's play going by the same title is the greatest soldier in Rome. First African tragedy playwrights seemed to have borrowed this idea of a highly placed tragic hero. For example in John Ruganda's ***The Burdens***, Wamala was at one time a Cabinet Minister, residing in the affluent areas of the city. But later life changes for the worst and Wamala becomes a *nobody* in as much as appertains to status. He is even forced to live in the slums. Kinjeketile in Ebrahim Hussein's ***Kinjeketile*** is also highly stationed. He is a respected diviner.

In modern tragedy, the tragic hero(ine) can also be isolated by society simply because of his/her tragic act, the status disregarding.

Tragedy is characterized with the individual struggle between the vitality of his life and the laws of nature. Oedipus in ***King Oedipus*** is fighting against the prophecy of a god. The more he tries to run away from the prophecy the more he unconsciously facilitates its fulfillment. The tragic hero feels compelled to do what he does fully aware that he is a special person and seeks to assert himself. In fact, the tragic hero falls not because of being malevolent/evil in his nature but simply because of a weakness in character. In literary terms, this weakness is called ***tragic flaw***. For example Oedipus is proud, Kinjeketile is impatient and King Lear is intransigent. These are normal human flaws/weaknesses and not vices. However, these limitations do not absolve the characters from being responsible for their actions. It is actions propelled by the characters' weaknesses that eventuate the fall of the tragic character. In ***The Burdens***, Wamala is responsible for his own actions even though he is unable to come to terms with his changed status. In his frustrations, he indulges in drinking heavily. He tries to command the dignity of his past to no avail. Tinka too is frustrated. What is more tragic about *The Burdens* is that in their frustrations, the couple ends up maiming and killing each other. Wamala dies at the hands of his wife. Certainly, tragedy comes with ***suffering***.

Another important feature of a tragedy is the element of *recognition*. At the end of the play the character is expected to know himself much better. Oedipus comes to discover that he killed his own father and married his own mother. In their deprivation, Tinka and Wamala come to learn of the self-centredness and inhumanity of the rich and ruling class.

11.3 Comedy

A *comedy* is a sustained play with a happy ending that is primarily designed to amuse. Even when a comedy encompasses sad incidents, these scenes of gloom always give way to scenes of joy and calmness. A man may get lost and later be found.

Characters in comedy are typically ordinary characters. If high stationed people like presidents or kings or government officials are used, they are presented as ordinary human beings. For example the government authorities in Nicolai Gogol's *The Government Inspector* are reduced to ordinary human beings, capable of being deceived by a windbag in the name of Hlestakov. Indeed, comedy deals with man in his human state. That is, comedy explores the physical, intellectual and emotional limitations of man as a rational *animal*.

Most comedies entail deception, disguise and mistaken identity. Hlestakov is mistaken for a government inspector and he is ready to cash in on the situation by deceiving the officials that he is undeniably the much-awaited inspector. The acting he engages in so as to convince the officials that he is the inspector amuses us. What are even more laughable are the kinds of acts the officials put up to placate "the inspector". Characters in comedies are certainly expected to be funny. The language of a comedy is also intended to provoke smiles and laughter. Comic speeches are generally characterized by some incongruity. For instance, following the news that the inspector is in town, the Mayor in *The Government Inspector*, in his confusion, commands his subject to "take the streets and sweep the broom".

11.4 Tragicomedy

A *tragicomedy* is a mixed form which employs a fusion of elements of both tragedy and drama. The actions and language in a tragicomedy are serious, disastrous and yet funny at the same time. Mirth/amusement is an important component of a tragicomedy. An impending catastrophe or 'near death' that does not happen elicits laughter. However, there is always a great component of despair. A character expects something to happen, it doesn't happen. He expects somebody to come but nobody comes. It is so awful. These disappointments are meant to demonstrate the uncertainty of life. The main characters in a tragic-comedy are usually whimsical/bizarre and funny.

In traditional drama, tragicomedies were tragedies that ended happily. In modern drama, tragicomedies are described as plays with mixed moods, which exhibit features of both tragedy and comedy. Tragicomedies may not necessarily end happily. Samuel Beckett's play *Waiting for Godot* is one famous tragicomedy. Others include: Shakespeare's *Measure for Measure*, Chekhov's *The Cherry Orchard* and Fletcher's *The Faithful Shepherdess*.

11.5 Farce

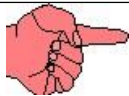
A *Farce* is a humorous play intended to excite laughter. Farce developed from comedy in the sense that whereas comedy makes fun with the intention of learning something from human folly, the ultimate aim of a farce is merely to entertain. In essence, farce climaxes in laughter. Characters in farce are outrageous and clownish yet of no serious consequence. In fact, farce carries neither an intellectual weight nor any serious moral. In farce, the actions are absurd, exaggerated and even improbable. For example: A thief is stealing from a car parked outside a supermarket. The owner comes just when the thief is rummaging through the boot but does not see the thief. The thief notices the car owner first but instead of taking to his heels, he hides quickly under the car. The owner of the car drives away and the thief is left lying on the road, unscathed. Or an adult found red-handed stealing food from the cooking pot trying to rationalize his obvious act. Indeed, characters in a farce are typically foolish, knave or utterly ridiculous.

In a farce, the actor is not responsible for his actions. He will go Scott free for an action that would be punishable in the other genres of drama.

A farce ends happily: A foolish man sends a letter meant for his girlfriend to his father. He realizes the mistake just after he has dropped the letter in the mailbox. He tries to stop the letter from leaving the post office to no avail. He follows the mail delivery van everywhere up to the neighbouring country where his father works. He manages to retrieve the letter from his father's in-tray just before the father arrives in the office.

Examples of farce include Shakespeare's *The Taming of the Shrew* and John Townley's *High Life Below Stairs*. Locally, the best example we have is the *Vitimbi* series. Some of the *Reddykyulass* and *Intru Kalas* episodes also are in actual fact farce in nature.

Note



- (1) Although the terms *tragedy*, *comedy* and *tragicomedy* were originally ascribed only to drama, in modern literature, these terms are also applied to prose works that exhibit the characteristics of such plays.
- (2) The types of drama discussed in this lecture are not the only ones. Many more exist and will be studied in detail in our third year drama course.

11.6 Summary



In this lecture we have dealt with forms of drama. We have looked at the different manifestations of thematic and stylistic presentation of the various types. We began by looking at the basic nature of tragedy. Next, we examined comedy. Thirdly, we looked at a form that combines both tragedy and comedy – the tragicomedy. Lastly we discussed the farce as an offshoot of comedy.

11.7 Activity



- (1) What is *tragedy*? What are its basic elements?
- (2) “Characters in comedies are much more ordinary than those in tragedies”. With illustrations from any text(s) of your choice, discuss this assertion.

LESSON TWELVE
ORAL LITERATURE

12.0 Introduction

This is our twelfth and last lecture in this course. In the previous lecture we examined various categories of drama. We looked at features that distinguish one dramatic genre from another. In this lecture we shall focus on a different genre of literature: *Oral Literature*.

Oral literature texts are varied. Some are presented in verse, others in prose. But many oral literature texts such as proverbs, riddles and tongue-twisters are expressed in forms that are entirely unique to oral literature. Even in verse and prose, oral literature texts behave differently from dramatic verse or written prose. In this lecture we will look at those elements that distinguish oral literature texts from other texts.

12.1 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Define the term 'Oral Literature'.
2. Distinguish oral literature texts from other genres of literature.
3. Describe the elements of oral literature.
4. Identify and describe various categories of oral literature.
5. Explain the social function of oral literature texts.
6. Explain the relationship between modern literature and oral tradition.
7. Explain the importance of fieldwork in the study of oral literature.

12.2 What is “Oral Literature”?

The term *oral literature* or *verbal art* refers to art whose medium is the spoken (or sung) word. Oral literature stretches back to antiquity, actually, to the beginning of society. Yet oral literature materials are still relevant to present day world. In current days, oral literature substance is even communicated in paper. However, the writers try to remain as faithful as possible to the oral rendition of the texts. Modern day literary genres evolved from oral literature. For example the short story as we know it today evolved from the folktale and the poetry evolved from chants, wayside poetry and court poetry of the traditional society.

For a long time, the western world privileged written literature over oral literature to the extent that European folklorists who studied African verbal art refused to acknowledge that there was anything artistic in that literature.

However, what determines the literariness of a text (whether written or spoken) is the artistic use of language and not its form (written or unwritten).

Oral literature operates differently from the written forms. It has unique features that occur in it mainly because this literature is given verbally. Therefore, oral literature needs to be studied differently.

Now let us focus on the unique features of oral literature:

(1) Speech – Oral, spoken word

We need not belabour the point that oral literature texts are expressed verbally. Now the act of speaking also involves other thing:

(2) Memory

Since an oral texts is delivered by mouth, this means that an artist must have the ability to hold the text to memory; intact with its traditional structures. This means that the artists must understand and

appreciate their culture and generic structures in order to be able to accurately reproduce the texts verbally.

(3) Aural/listening skills

We cannot understand something spoken unless we hear it. An artist will contrast his voice intonation to express pity, sadness, love, contempt, anger, awe and many more feelings. An audience needs a keen ear to discern all the different shades of intonations and their meaning.

(4) Visual capacity

Oral texts are not just read aloud but performed. For effective communication, the artist must support his spoken words with gestures and correct body movement. In essence then, an oral text must be appreciated with both the eye and ear in order to understand it.

(5) Artist's Presence

Performance means that an artist must be present. An audiocassette or video recording of a performance will not have the impact that a live artist would have on the audience. Besides, an artist will vary and adjust his text and style of performance according to the audience.

(6) Audience

There is always a necessity that the performer performs in front of people. The audience is important since doing things to the audience shapes the performer's art, making sure that his point is understood to a particular audience. The audience is the target of composition. There is much relationship between the artist and audience in oral literature. The strength of an oral performance also emanates from the audience's participation. The audience responds to the presentation, gives

comments and opinion concerning the composition such that in the final analysis, an artist may be compelled to present a version different from what he had in mind before he began his performance. This means that the artist has to be a fast thinker, capable of improvising and re-composing depending on the audience.

An oral text therefore entails an aspect of communal composition. In different circumstances, an artist will find himself giving a very different presentation of the same text.

(7) Culturally defined occasion/function

Whereas written literature can be read any time, there are specific contexts and times for performance of oral literature texts. For example in the traditional African set-up, narratives would be told after work or during serious discussions. Appropriate songs would also be sung according to the social occasion: circumcision, naming, funeral, wedding e.t.c. Proverbs were mainly the domain of the elderly while in most societies riddles were the domain of children.

Now these context-specific forms of literature are what we call genres, categories or classes of oral literature. The function of a genre delimits its performance.

12.3 Genres of Oral Literature

(i) Oral narratives

These are tales in prose handed down from many generations. Oral narratives come in many forms or sub-genres. They include: folktales, stories, tales, myths, legends and epics. Since it is not within our jurisdiction in this course to delve into the elements of these categories, we will only clarify in summary and with examples that these tales deal with specific themes.

Fables are pure fiction and employ animal characters to comment on human beings. Myth and legends have a mystical and historical concept such as: why things are the way they are. For example “The Women’s cattle” in Naomi Kipury’s *Oral Literature of the Maasai* is a myth on how women irresponsibly lost their cattle by letting them wander away. This myth explains not only why women do not own cattle or any property in the Maasai community, but also justifies the maltreatment of women by men. Myths are also called aetiological/etiological tales. “The Origin of Marriage” is another etiological tale in Kipury’s text that illustrates women’s folly brought about by marriage.

Women have to be given off because they are purportedly so libidinous that they can even betray their own brothers. This myth explains the subordinate position that the Maasai woman still holds. Other myths in Kipury’s book include “The Sun and the Moon”, which explains a natural phenomenon, that is, why the sun shines brightest and the moon just a little bright. “Thunder and the gods” explains the mystery of thunder. “The Fall of the Dog” enlightens on why the dog lives with man and why it has long ears and a very good sense of smell.

Whereas ogre stories and fables discuss human qualities indirectly by use of animal characters, tales or stories are direct commentaries on the life of people. From these stories we get a complete picture of the social set-up, dietary and other social habits and taboos, kinship and other relations, sex roles, beliefs, values, attitudes and philosophy of life. Like other oral tales, these stories had a moral lesson. They would castigate greed, cruelty, robbery, selfishness, ingratitude and maltreatment of the weak by the strong. Asenath Odaga’s *Yesterday’s Today*,

Naomi Kipury’s *Oral Literature of the Masaai* and Ciarunji Chesaina’s *Oral Literature of the Kalenjin*, among other works, have many examples of such stories. “The Greedy Old Man and the Sausage” is one story in Kipury’s book that lashes at gluttony. “The Children of the Sycamore Tree” explains why children are valued in the Maasai community.

(2) Oral Poetry / Songs

We mentioned elsewhere (under Poetry) in this course that there were several types of special poets in the African traditional society. The Court poets and diviners functioned in a restricted field of operation in that they were trained in a particular type of poetry only. The court poet's role would be to sing the king's praises. He would also sing about significant historical events surrounding the royal family. The diviner would chant poems related to the special problems brought to him by his clients. The court poet and diviner attained their positions after a long period of formal training and their forms of poetry were handed down from one generation to another. The fact that such poets were trained in a special form of poetry does not mean that this was simply mechanical poetry. In spite of the restricted nature of these poetic forms, the poet still had to depend on his imagination to recreate the same texts in different occasions and circumstances.

Also, the court poet did not just praise a king. In case of failure on the part of the

king, the court poet would cleverly and cautiously admonish the king in a manner that would not provoke the king's wrath.

Within the general poetry/song, we also have sub-categories. Such sub-categories include: birth, war songs, praise songs, political songs, dirges, initiation songs, teasing songs, work songs, lullabies and marriage songs, among others. Indeed, in the traditional African society there were songs for each stage of a person's life and every occasion. These songs and poetry expressed the people's philosophies, beliefs, values and even their historical development.

Activity

Choose a song or poem from any oral literature text of your choice and (i) discuss its thematic concerns.

(ii) identify and explain any imagery drawn from the setting.

(3) Proverbs

Proverbs are terse pithy statements of keen observation and ingenious generalization. Proverbs are **Terse** in the sense that they are normally compact and brief. **Pithy** means that proverbs are imbued with wisdom and truth about life.

Proverbs can further be divided into sub-genres according to themes: proverbs on religion, kinship relations, gender roles, war, fairness, patience and perseverance, foolishness, hope, fate and many more. However, like stories, songs and poetry, the themes of proverbs may also overlap. Classification of proverbs should therefore only be used to facilitate reading and academic discussions and must not be taken rigidly.

(4) Riddles

Riddles are enigmatic questions aimed at making a person use his wit to unravel them. Essentially then, riddles encompass a question and answer. There are two types of riddles:

(a) **Enigmas** – These are metaphorical in their nature and involve comparison, association and analogy. For example:

- 1) Q: I have a son with many coats A: A cob of maize
- 2) Q: A Land Rover in the forest A:
A Louse in the hair
- 3) Q: My Grandfather fell and urinated
A: Cashew fruit which when very ripe falls from its tree and its juice oozes out.

(b) **Conundrums** – These are usually more complicated than the enigmas in the sense that they may come in the form of dilemma stories or they may simply be based on punning or sound effect rather than the meaning. For example:

1) Q: Amaa, naaya, o naayieu, o naaipieu. Kainyioo?

A:

Enkaya, enkiyieu, o ilkipieu (Maasai)

(founded on sound outcome)

2) Q: I have three things: a leopard, a goat and sweet potato vines. I want to cross the river but I cannot cross with more than one thing at a time. If I take the leopard and leave the goat with the vines, the goat will eat the vines. If I take the vines and leave the leopard with the goat, the leopard will eat the goat. How shall I cross?

A: First, take the goat and leave the leopard with the potato

vines. Then take the potato vines and leave them on the other side of the river. Come back with the goat. Next, take the leopard across. Leave it with the potato vines. Finally, come take the goat across. This way you will take them all across safely.

Anyone can think out the answer to the second conundrum by using just one principle: there should be no time when something which can eat the other should be left with that thing. Also, if one remembers that there is among these three one thing that cannot eat the others, and also it can only be eaten by one of the three, then one can easily work out an answer.

Working one's way through the odd man out, one gets the answer. In a riddle like this, one cannot just come out with an answer in a split of a second as one could do with most of the simpler riddles. This kind of riddle requires more thinking and puzzling out.

Riddles are usually associated with children. Indeed, they are favourite with children.

This is because riddles are a kind of game; play. Playing is characteristic of children and certainly the affirmation that man is a playing animal is seen in childhood.

Children enjoy and learn in play. The game of riddling is also more often than not done in a relaxed atmosphere. Also, as a form of entertainment for children, riddles heavily encompass humour and laughter.

These are central thoughts for children. Children themselves exhibit humour and laughter. Hence, they enjoy and are best taught through these. The solving of the

problem evokes humour since it is a question followed by an incongruous answer. The listener tries to see how the incongruous answer relates to the question. The incongruity evokes pleasure and humour. For example

- 1) Q: You are staggering my son in law, where did you take beer? A: The chameleon
- 2) Q: Old men round a beer pot A: Flies on a mound of shit

At first encounter, the answer or association between the question and answer in the two examples appears nonsensical and incomparable. However, after some time people see the relationship and the humour comes out. The incongruous answer is usually unexpected. In the second example, the incongruity is manifested in the comparison between old men and flies and beer to a mound of shit – something unpalatable. This riddle also comments on the communal tradition of feasting (sharing) while at the same time criticizing the idea of sitting around, drinking beer. The repercussions after beer drinking could be akin and as adverse as flies landing on people's food with all the dirt after feasting on excreta. Likewise, beer drinking may precipitate irresponsible acts like thoughtless physical confrontations and verbal insults.

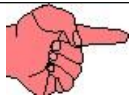
In most communities all over the world, children are the creators of the simpler riddles. Their creation usually derives from their keen observation of their society and environment.

Riddles, though explicitly meant for amusement, sometimes play an indirect role by training children in quick thinking, in intellectual skill and in classification. They are sometimes like proverbs, used as indirect means of saying something without the risk involved in stating it explicitly. Less common are the incidental functions of the more complex riddles as a form of communication, an esoteric accomplishment associated with initiation, and the encouragement of either sharing

or competitiveness implicit in various forms of riddling. In various societies, these indirect functions of riddle-asking have greater or lesser significance. What all seem to share, however, is the explicit assumption that riddles or at least the simple form of riddles is primarily for entertainment and, unlike proverbs, not for any deeper purpose.

Though riddles are regarded as art merely for children, they nevertheless have some relevance for the general literary background. This comes out partly through their connection with other literary forms such as proverbs, epigrams, songs, praise names and rhetoric. More significantly, the imagery and poetic comment of even the simple riddles are clearly part of the general literary culture.

Note



- (i) Generic classifications should not be taken rigidly. It is possible to find a fable which is a myth at the same time. Sometimes the classifications are determined by the source. This is because some categories of oral literature may vary according to the society from which they originate.
- (ii) The classification of oral literature material also depends on the needs of whoever is classifying the genre.

12.4 Social function of Oral literature

Oral literature is an expression of and a reservoir of a people's *culture*. Now, what is *culture*? *Culture* encompasses a people's civilization, customs, life style, stage

of development and their art. According to Ali Mazrui, an African political scientist/thinker, **culture** is a system of inter-related values, active enough to influence and condition perception, judgement, communication and behaviour in a given society. In that regard, Oral literature expresses a people's values and the kinds of hopes and aspirations that the society has. It is also a vehicle that gives a society a sense of direction. It also gives a society a sense of order. It expresses a people's needs and expectations at a given time in the course of their historical development. Linked to that, Oral literature is a creative record of a people's history.

Oral literature reflects a people's worldview, that is, attitude towards certain phenomena and behaviour. For example it is easy to discern the attitude of society towards its women and children. Proverbs are perhaps the best genre in Oral literature in expressing a people's worldview.

Oral literature is didactic. It educates on the history, culture and values of a people. This makes it a useful tool for socialization of the youth. In that regard, Oral literature is also important in the development of identity. As the Swahili proverb goes "Mkosa mila ni mtumwa" (he who does not have his own culture is a slave), as an expression/reservoir of culture, Oral literature accords a person a backbone or foundation on which to stand.

12.5 Function of Oral literature in modern writing

The contemporary creative writer finds a sense of identity or foundation in his own culture which is expressed by Oral literature. Talking about West African literature in his article entitled "Cultural nationalism in Modern African Writing" in *African Literature Today* Vol. 1, Obiechina says:

The West African writer is impelled in his writing to strengthen the cultural present with a metrics of the old traditional West African culture. Under the prevailing Cultural nationalism he

stands or falls by how successfully he has undertaken this duty in his writing.

Actually, Oral literature forms give African writers not just an identity but an idiom of expression that distinguishes African literature from that of the rest of the world. African Writers such as Ngugi wa Thiong'o, Chinua Achebe and Okot P'bitek, among others, have depended heavily on oral literature for their modern day literary creations. In *Things Fall Apart*, Chinua Achebe uses numerous idioms, proverbs and even narratives. Chinua Achebe literally translates Ibo idioms/expressions into English. An expression like "proverbs are the palm oil with which words are eaten" does not only illuminate on the great importance of proverbs in Ibo talk but also sheds light on the great value ascribed to palm oil in the Ibo society. This is also an indigenous expression that may not make significant meaning to a person who comes from a different culture that, for example, does not appreciate the importance of palm oil. Also, in both *Things Fall Apart* and *Arrow of God*, Achebe portrays the African world in relation to the supernatural and the metaphysical. Ngugi also employs Agikuyu myths of creation and origin in both *The River Between* and *A Grain of Wheat*.

As concerns drama, firstly, it should be appreciated that drama originated from oral tradition in the sense that the earliest dramatic works emanated from ritual performance. Traditional drama also subsisted on mythology. It was also characterized by use of cultural elements of song, dance, costume and drumming. Whereas masks were used to conceal the identity of the characters, drums and songs were employed to liven up the performance. Indeed, there were no quiet interludes in traditional drama. A drum would be played in the interlude or a song would be sung backstage. Songs were also sung in the background as the performance went on in order to facilitate establishing the right mood. In this regard it will be noted that most of classical plays, if not all, had a chorus. Besides establishing the correct mood, the chorus also helped the audience understand the performance better by singing songs that were thematically related to the on-goings (actions on stage). Modern playwrights have also benefited from oral tradition. For example, Francis Imbuga's *Betrayal in the City* hinges on oral tradition in the sense

that it grows out of the African's superstitious worldview of the living and the dead. Every event and theme revolves around or draws its significance from the death of Adika. In John Ruganda's *The Floods*, we encounter the myth of Nyamgondho, the sea goddess. Modern writers have also benefited from oral tradition in terms of characterization of their fictional personages. For example Okonkwo in *Things Fall Apart* and Ezeulu in *Arrow of God* are not just people, they represent or are symbolic of their societies' traditions.

12.6 Fieldwork in Oral literature

When we looked at basic/distinguishing elements of Oral literature, we saw the importance of performance. It is therefore important for you to go to the field to experience an oral performance in order to fully understand an oral item than just reading the Oral literature material that has been put on paper. Experiencing the performance of an Oral item in its original context and presentation will also enable you to fully appreciate the factors that shape oral literature genres. Oral literature genres are better rendered in their original language and context. Arranged performances always lack something in the sense that the artist performs consciously and not spontaneously as he would in the original context. The artist therefore may tend to be formal in an arranged presentation and sometimes he may leave out some crucial aspects of Oral performance.

While in the field, it is possible to experience a performance through *participation* or *observation*. Participation enables you to feel from within as if you were an insider of that community. Observation also has the advantage of allowing you to objectively notice what you may have not noticed if you were subjectively part and parcel of the performance

Fieldwork is also important in oral literature since it enables a scholar record the folk literature of his people, which had previously only existed in memory.

Fieldwork therefore helps us preserve our oral tradition.

When collecting Oral literature material you need to consider the following factors:

- (i) Genre/category – You should identify the genre and specify the type - exact class/sub-genre of the genre.
- (ii) Source of Origin – you should identify the geographical or ethnic origin of the text. You also need to get a fair understanding of the historical, cultural, political and economic background and life style of the people.
- (iii) Social significance – you should be able to explain the social implication of the performance or context of the genre.

All these should help guide your exploration and appreciation of the generic features.

12.7 Summary



In this lecture we have looked at Oral literature as a genre of literature. We began by defining the term “Oral Literature” and its appropriateness/inappropriateness. Next, we looked at four categories or genres of Oral literature, namely: Oral tales/narratives, songs/poetry, proverbs and riddles. Thirdly, we discussed the general social and artistic functions/value of oral literature. Lastly, we discussed fieldwork and its importance to the study of oral literature.

12.8 Activity



- (1) Outline the basic components of oral literature and explain their significance.
- (2) Consider the appropriateness and inappropriateness of the term “Verbal Art” when applied to Oral literature.
- (3) What is the difference between Oral literature and drama?

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